

Fate's Edge

System Reference Document

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Quickstart

The Core Loop in Brief

1. **Declare intent and approach.** What do you do and how?
2. **GM sets Position and Difficulty (DV).**
 - Position: **Dominant** (advantage), **Controlled** (balanced), **Desperate** (high risk).
 - DV: 2 (routine) to 5+ (extreme). Default DV = 3.
3. **Roll dice.** Pool = Attribute + Skill (d10s). Each 6–9 = 1 success; each 10 = 2 successes.
4. **Count Story Beats (SB).** Each die showing a 1 gives the GM 1 SB.
5. **Compare successes to DV.** Use the outcome matrix.

Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	Outcome	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success	Intent achieved; no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success & SB	Intent achieved; GM spends SB to add a complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial	Make progress, but with a cost; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss	No progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

Boons (Player Resource)

- Earn 1 Boon on a **Partial**, 2 Boons on a **Miss**.
- Maximum 5 Boons; trim to 2 at scene end.
- Spend 1 Boon to: re-roll a single die, activate an Asset, or improve Position by one step.
- During downtime, convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (max 2 XP per session).

Story Beats (GM Resource)

Each 1 on a player's die gives the GM 1 SB. Spend SB to introduce complications:

SB	SB	Effect
1		Minor pressure: noise, trace, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1.
2		Moderate setback: alarm raised, lose Position, a lesser foe appears.
3		Serious trouble: reinforcements, key gear breaks, advance a campaign timer.
4+		Major turn: trap springs, authority arrives, environment shifts dramatically.

Position and Effect

- **Position** (risk): Dominant (safe), Controlled (normal), Desperate (high stakes).
- **Effect** (reward): Limited, Standard, Great.
- Spending 1 Boon before a roll improves Position by one step.
- The GM may spend SB to worsen Position.

Fatigue and Harm

- **Fatigue** track = Body. Each Fatigue point worsens Position by one step. At Desperate, each Fatigue gives -1 die.
- **Harm** levels: 1 (-1 die on related actions), 2 (-1 die on most actions), 3 (incapacitated).
- **Armor converts Harm to Fatigue.** Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.
- Taking Harm clears all existing Fatigue (the shock of injury resets exhaustion).

Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Quick Reference: Defaults

- Default DV = 3.
- Default Position = Controlled.
- Default Effect = Standard.
- Default Range = Near (unless otherwise stated).

Example of Play (One Minute)

Lyra (Wits 3 + Tinker 2 = 5 dice) tries to pick a lock while a guard patrol approaches.

- GM: "Controlled, DV 3. On a Miss, the guard hears you."
- Roll: 9, 6, 4, 2, 1 → 2 successes vs DV 3 → *Partial*. Lyra gains 1 Boon. The 1 gives the GM 1 SB.
- GM: "The lock clicks open, but the last pin squeals. I spend the SB: the guard stops and turns his head. You have one beat to hide."

Next Steps

- For full character creation, see Section ??.
- For magic, talents, and equipment, see Sections ??–??.
- For GMs: advice, NPC templates, and optional systems are in Sections ??–??.

1 Core Principles

1.1 Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Before play, establish how the table handles sensitive content. Fate’s Edge uses three standard tools.

X-Card

Any player (including the GM) may draw an X on a card or simply say “X” when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is removed from the fiction — no questions, no explanations, no judgments. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines

A Line is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils

A Veil is a soft boundary: content that can happen off screen or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

1.2 Player-Managed Modules

Players track their character-facing resources to reduce GM overhead and keep play flowing:

- **Obligation** (per Patron, marked when Rites are invoked/pushed).
- **Corruption Timer** (for Cantors, marked when pushing Songs or GM spends SB on occult actions).
- **Leash** (for Summoners, marked when spirits take harm, act against nature, split focus, or cross wards).
- **Asset States** (Symbol/Item condition: Maintained, Neglected, or Compromised).

GMs retain all world-facing elements: Timers, NPCs, faction moves, Patron intrusions, and narrative consequences. *Why this matters:* When players manage their own modules, the GM spends less time bookkeeping and more time driving the story. Always verify player tracking at scene start/end (see Section ??). *Design Note:* This rule prevents “GM as accountant” syndrome. If a player forgets to track a module, the GM does not correct it mid-scene—instead, note it for downtime resolution. Trust fosters faster play.

1.3 What Is Fate’s Edge?

Fate’s Edge is a narrative-first tabletop roleplaying system where every action carries weight, every choice has consequence, and even failure feeds the story. Dice are not merely success meters — they are instruments of fate, weaving opportunity with risk.

*“The road remembers. Every broken wheel leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness.
The only question is: what are you willing to owe?”*

1.4 The Central Question

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to surrender, to reshape the world around you?

1.5 Tone of Play

- **Cinematic:** Scenes breathe; tense exchanges resolve in moments.
- **Consequential:** A whispered secret can topple a kingdom; a missed roll can spare a life.
- **Collaborative:** The GM sets stakes; the players drive the fiction.

1.6 Key Concepts

1.6.1 Narrative Time

Time is measured by story weight, not by timers:

- **A Moment:** a heartbeat, a strike, a whispered word.
- **Some Time:** a few minutes — a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
- **Significant Time:** hours — travel between locations, a ritual, an interrogation.
- **Days:** marches across countryside, training a cadre, recovery from serious harm.

1.6.2 Story Beats (SB)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a die, the GM gains a Story Beat. SB are narrative currency — spend them to introduce complications, escalate tension, shift Position, or advance timers.

1.6.3 Affinity

Each culture grants an Affinity — a narrative edge or metaphysical bond that makes certain actions more reliable (e.g., Aeler stone-sense, Aelaerem hearth-luck). Affinities are described in the full cultural guides.

Note on Stacking. If your ancestral gift (from your people) and your cultural affinity provide the same benefit (e.g., both improve Position), they do not stack. You may use one per scene. Choose which applies when you need it.

1.6.4 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural or arcane arts. They are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

1.6.5 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

- **On-Screen:** followers, allies, companions who stand beside you in a scene.
- **Off-Screen:** assets, titles, informants, safe houses — resources that act when you spend Boons or during downtime.

1.7 Boons Overview

Boons are narrative tokens earned primarily by failing rolls with meaningful consequences. They represent momentum, luck, or a second wind.

Earning Boons:

- **Partial** ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$): Gain 1 Boon.
- **Miss** ($\text{successes} = 0$): Gain 2 Boons (provided the roll was meaningful and generated at least one SB).
- **Bond-driven action:** Once per bond per session, when you act meaningfully on a Mutual Bond and provide an Intricate Description, gain 1 Boon.
- **GM award:** For creative solutions, sacrifices, or outstanding roleplay.

Spending Boons:

- Re-roll a single die after seeing the pool.
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities as described in their text.
- During downtime, convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (once per session; max 2 XP per session via conversion).

Limits:

- Maximum 5 Boons held at any time.
- At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess are lost).
- At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- Repetition rule: the same action with the same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.

1.8 GM Guidelines for Timers and SB

To keep the game flowing and avoid overwhelming the table:

- **Timer Limit:** Maintain at most three active timers per scene. Combine redundant timers or treat additional timers as off-screen campaign timers (ticked between scenes as a result of scene outcomes).
- **SB Banking:** Try to keep banked SB (unspent at scene end) under **Tier + 1** (e.g., Tier I: max 2 SB, Tier II: max 3 SB). Unspent SB beyond this may carry over (GM discretion, max 4).
- **Terminology:** Use “Success with SB” instead of “Success & Cost” for clarity — it emphasizes the narrative opportunity rather than a penalty.

1.9 Fail Forward: Every Roll Matters

- A **Clean Success** advances the fiction without added friction.
- A **Success with SB** achieves the goal but introduces a complication (GM spends SB).
- A **Partial** makes meaningful progress and gives the player a Boon.
- A **Miss** fails to achieve the goal, gives the player 2 Boons, and gives the GM SB to escalate.

No roll should result in “nothing happens.” Every outcome changes the situation.

2 Core Mechanic

2.1 The Resolution Loop

Every action that carries risk and uncertainty follows these five steps.

1. **Declare intent and approach.** The player states what they want to accomplish and how (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets Position and Difficulty (DV).**
 - Position: Dominant (advantage), Controlled (normal), Desperate (high risk).
 - DV: 2 (routine) to 5+ (extreme). Default DV = 3.

3. **Roll dice.** Pool = Attribute + Skill (d10s). Count successes:
 - 6–9 = 1 success.
 - 10 = 2 successes.
4. **Count Story Beats (SB).** Each die showing a 1 gives the GM 1 SB.
5. **Apply the Outcome Matrix.**

2.2 Critical Success

Rolling a **10** (counting as 2 successes) creates additional benefits:

- **One 10:** Choose one – gain a free Boon, improve Position by one step, or add a narrative flourish.
- **Two 10s:** Choose two benefits or one powerful effect (e.g., ignore armor + gain tactical advantage).
- **Three+ 10s:** Legendary success – resolve the conflict dramatically and advance a secondary timer or create a significant story development.

Note: 10s are never re-rolled (even in Desperate position). Critical effects apply only if the roll succeeds (Successes $\geq$ DV).

2.3 Difficulty Values (DV)

DV	Situation
2	Routine, low stakes, nearly guaranteed.
3	Default – pressured or minor opposition.
4	Hard – hostile conditions, active resistance.
5	Extreme – multiple constraints, dramatic gambles.
6+	Nearly impossible – requires exceptional setup or mythic aid.

2.4 Position & Effect

- **Position (Risk)**
 - **Dominant:** Re-roll one failure (die $\leq$ 5).
 - **Controlled:** No re-rolls.
 - **Desperate:** Re-roll one success (die $\geq$ 6). 10s are never re-rolled.
- **Effect (Reward)**
 - **Limited:** Minimal outcome.
 - **Standard:** Expected outcome.
 - **Great:** Strong outcome with additional benefit.
- **Modifiers:**

- Player may spend 1 Boon before rolling to improve Position by one step.
- GM may spend SB to worsen Position or reduce Effect.
- If bonuses would raise Position above Dominant, each extra step becomes +1 die.
- If penalties would drop Position below Desperate, each extra step becomes –1 die.

2.5 Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	Outcome	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success	Intent achieved; no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success with SB	Intent achieved; GM spends SB for a complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial	Progress made; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss	No progress; player gains 2 Boons; GM escalates with SB.

2.6 Boons (Player Resource)

2.6.1 Earning Boons

- Partial: gain 1 Boon.
- Miss: gain 2 Boons (if the roll was meaningful and generated at least one SB).
- Bond-driven action (once per bond per session): gain 1 Boon.
- GM award (creative solutions, sacrifices, outstanding roleplay).

2.6.2 Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die after seeing the pool (keep second result; new 1s generate additional SB).
- Activate an Asset (on-screen).
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities.
- Convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (downtime, once per session, max 2 XP).

2.6.3 Limits

- Max 5 Boons held.
- At end of each scene, reduce to max 2 (excess lost).
- At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene (repetition of same action + stakes does not award another Boon).

2.7 Story Beats (GM Resource)

Every die showing a 1 gives the GM 1 Story Beat (SB). Spend SB to introduce complications or escalate pressure.

Guidelines:

- 1 SB: minor – noise, trace, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1.
- 2 SB: moderate – alarm raised, lose Position, lesser foe appears.
- 3 SB: serious – reinforcements, key gear breaks, advance a campaign timer.
- 4+ SB: major – trap springs, authority arrives, environment shifts dramatically.

2.8 NPCs and Resources

Non-player characters do **not** track Fatigue or Boons. If an ability would cause an NPC to lose these resources, convert it into a narrative consequence:

- Instead of “loses 1 Boon” → “hesitates – loses next action”.
- Instead of “marks 1 Fatigue” → “staggers – next attack at Desperate Position”.
- Instead of “loses 1 Boon and marks 1 Fatigue” → “drops weapon (disarmed) and stumbles back one range band”.

2.9 NPC Special Abilities as SB Spends

Instead of rolling for NPC abilities, the GM may spend Story Beats to trigger narrative events.

Example SB Spends:

- **1 SB:** “The cultist’s eyes burn – mark 1 Fatigue (near miss).”
- **2 SB:** “The spider drops on you – you are Grappled (escape DV 3).”
- **3 SB:** “The drake breathes frost – everyone in Near, test Body+Athletics (DV 3) or take Harm 2.”
- **4+ SB:** “The lich raises its hand – test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be Paralyzed for 1 exchange.”

The GM narrates the effect; players roll to resist.

2.10 Assistance

- One helper per action.
- Total assist dice capped at +3 (unless a talent says otherwise).
- Assistant accepts any risk named by the GM.

2.11 Fatigue and Harm

2.11.1 Fatigue

- Track size = Body (minimum 1).
- Each point worsens Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate).
- If already Desperate, each additional Fatigue imposes −1 die on all rolls.

2.11.2 Harm

Harm Level	Effect
1	−1 die on related actions (GM discretion).
2	−1 die on most actions until treated.
3	Incapacitated or dying.

2.11.3 Taking Harm Clears Fatigue (Roller-Coaster)

1. Convert incoming Harm to Fatigue using **Armor Conversion Table**.
2. Apply any remaining Harm. If Harm remains, clear all existing Fatigue, then increase Harm level by amount taken.
3. Add Fatigue from step 1 to Fatigue track. If track fills, increase Harm by 1 and clear all Fatigue.

2.11.4 Armor Conversion Table

Armor	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

2.11.5 Recovery

- Fatigue: Short rest (1 hour) removes 2; full night's rest removes all.
- Harm: Requires medical care (Medicine roll) or magical healing; natural recovery takes one week per level.

2.12 Maximum Dice Pool

Maximum die pool = 10d10. Any additional dice beyond 10 become automatic successes (1 auto-success per extra die).

2.13 Over-Stack Rule

To prevent trivializing scenes through excessive pre-scene preparation:

- **Trigger:** Party enters a scene with 3 or more **structural advantages** (checked once, at scene framing).
- **Effect:** GM chooses one – increase DV of one obstacle by +1, or gain +1 SB.
- **Limit:** Applies at most once per scene.

Structural Advantages (examples):

- Two or more scene-long buffs on the party.
- Unused Follower Initiative from previous scene.
- Asset activation granting a bonus at scene start.
- Opponent is Surprised, Trapped, or disadvantaged by prior setup.
- Ritual completed before the scene that affects the scene's conditions.

Not structural:

- Single buff or spell.
- Advantages created during the scene (e.g., Setup action).
- Flavor or purely narrative preparation.

3 Character Creation

3.1 Starting Build Points

Characters begin with **32 XP** to allocate during initial creation. This represents a balanced baseline for competent starting characters.

3.2 Enhanced Starting Builds

Players may exceed the standard 32 XP build through narrative engagement:

- **Bonds:** Up to two player-defined mutual bonds may be taken for +2 XP total. (See Section ?? for bond-driven Boon rules.)
- **Complications:** Up to two initial complications may be accepted for +4 XP total. Each complication causes scenes to start with +1 banked SB per character with that complication until the complication has been resolved in play.

This allows a maximum starting build of **36 XP**. Players are encouraged to aim for 32 XP and use bonds and complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimization.

3.3 Step-by-Step Creation

3.3.1 Step 1: Concept and Culture

Describe your character in a sentence. Choose a cultural background (e.g., Aeler, Ykrul, Vilikari, Lethai). Cultural affinities provide narrative edges described in the full cultural guides.

3.3.2 Step 2: Attributes

Distribute 1, 2, 2, 3 among the four attributes (minimum 1, maximum 3 at start). Cost to raise attributes later is new rating $\times$ 3 XP.

Attribute	Description
Body	Strength, endurance, physical resilience.
Wits	Perception, speed, quick thinking.
Spirit	Willpower, focus, connection to the intangible.
Presence	Charisma, command, force of personality.

3.3.3 Step 3: Skills

Distribute 6 points among skills (maximum 2 in any skill at start). Cost to raise skills later is new level $\times$ 2 XP.

Core skills include:

- Melee
- Ranged
- Brawl
- Athletics
- Stealth
- Endurance
- Craft
- Survival
- Sway
- Command
- Deception
- Performance
- Insight
- Lore
- Investigation
- Medicine
- Arcana
- Ritual

3.3.4 Step 4: Talents

Spend XP on talents. Recommended starting talents for common archetypes:

Archetype	Recommended Talents
Warrior	Weapon Master (5 XP), Effortless Charge (4 XP), Conditioning (4 XP)
Rogue	Keen Senses (2 XP), Trackless Step (2 XP), Backstab (6 XP)
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)
Runekeeper	Familiar (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)
Invoker	Patron's Symbol (4 XP)
Summoner	Pact-Whisperer (2 XP) + Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)
Support	Field Dressing (2 XP), Medic's Hand (3 XP), Inspire (3 XP)

3.3.5 Step 5: Equipment

Choose starting equipment based on concept. See Section ?? for weapon, armor, and gear tables.

3.3.6 Step 6: Bonds

Define 1–2 mutual bonds with other player characters. Each bond gives:

- Once per session, when you act meaningfully on the bond and provide an Intricate Description, gain 1 Boon.
- Bonded allies may gift 2 Boons per scene to each other (instead of the normal 1).

A bond should include:

- A shared history or obligation.
- What each character gains from the bond.
- A potential source of tension.

3.3.7 Step 7: Complications (Optional)

Choose 0–2 complications. Each gives +2 XP at start. Complications should be narrative hooks, not purely mechanical penalties. Examples:

- **Debt to a Patron:** You owe Obligation segments to a Patron before play begins.
- **Hunted:** A faction or individual seeks you.
- **Forbidden Knowledge:** You carry a secret that could destroy you if revealed.
- **Cursed Lineage:** Ancestral curse manifests at dramatic moments.
- **Oath-Bound:** A geas compels certain actions; breaking it has steep costs.

For each complication taken, at the start of each scene the GM gains +1 SB until the complication is resolved in play.

3.3.8 Step 8: Finalize

Record starting Fatigue (0), Harm (0), Boons (0). Note any starting Assets or Followers (see Section ??).

3.4 Quick Build Templates

3.4.1 Fighter (32 XP)

Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 2
Skills: Melee 2, Athletics 2, Endurance 1, Command 1
Talents: Weapon Master (5 XP), Conditioning (4 XP), Effortless Charge (4 XP)
Equipment: Medium weapon, medium armor
Bond: One mutual bond
Complication: None

3.4.2 Rogue (32 XP)

Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 2, Presence 2
Skills: Stealth 2, Subterfuge 2, Sway 2, Tinker 1
Talents: Keen Senses (2 XP), Silk Palms (2 XP), Backstab (6 XP)
Equipment: Light weapons, light armor, lockpicks
Bond: One mutual bond
Complication: None

3.4.3 Caster (32 XP)

Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 1
Skills: Arcana 2, Lore 2, Insight 1, Investigation 1
Talents: Spellcraft (6 XP)
Equipment: Staff, robes, focus (crystal, runestone, or inkpot)
Bond: One mutual bond
Complication: None

3.5 Learning Through Examples

See how core mechanics apply to the QuickBuild Templates (Sections ??-??):

Lockpick Under Pressure (Lyra the Rogue, Section ??):

- GM: “Controlled, DV 3. On a miss, the guard hears you.”
- Lyra rolls [9, 6, 4, 2, 1] (Wits 4 + Tinker 2 = 6 dice) → 2 successes (DV 3 Partial) → **Gains 1 Boon.**

- The 1 gives GM 1 SB: “The lock clicks open, but the last pin squeals. I spend the SB: the guard stops and turns his head. You have one beat to hide.”

→ *Teaches*: Partial success = progress + Boon; 1s = GM currency for complications.

Arcane Backlash (Sera the Caster, Section ??):

- Sera casts [FIRE][STRIKE] (DV 3) vs. a fire elemental → rolls [10, 1, 1] (Wits 4 + Arcana 2 = 6 dice) → 3 successes (10=2, 1s=2 SB) → **Success with SB** (GM spends 1 SB for complication).
- Backlash: Dominant element is Fire → GM describes: “The bolt hits, but the flash blinds you—your next action is Desperate. Smoke triggers a hanging lantern; the room starts catching fire (Clock: Fire Spread [4]).”

→ *Teaches*: 1s generate SB *even on success*; elemental backlash coloring; SB spent on visible consequences.

Tip for New GMs: Run these examples at your table. Ask: “What would you do with Lyra’s Boon?” or “How does Sera’s backlash change the scene?”

3.6 Advanced Start: Tier II (80 XP)

For campaigns beginning at higher power, characters may start with 80 XP. In addition to the 32 XP baseline, add:

- +2 attribute points (raise any attributes; maximum 4).
- +8 skill points (maximum skill 3 at start; raise to 4 later).
- Additional talents worth approximately 48 XP.
- One Minor Asset (4 XP) or one Follower (Cap 2).
- One additional bond or complication (narrative only; no extra XP).

3.7 Session Zero Tips

- Establish the table’s tone and stakes; tie character goals to campaign fronts.
- Map Bonds among PCs; mark possible bond-driven Boon triggers.
- Seed 1–2 personal Complications per PC for early spotlight.
- Discuss Patron choices (if any) and what their omens look like.
- Review Safety Tools (Lines, Veils, X-Card) before play begins.

3.8 Build Point Summary

Element	Cost (XP)	Starting Max
Attribute (per point)	$3 \times$ new rating	3
Skill (per point)	$2 \times$ new level	2
Talent	varies	—
Bond (mutual)	+1 XP each (2 total)	2
Complication	+2 XP each (2 total)	2
Minor Asset	4 XP	1
Follower (Cap 2)	2 XP	1

3.8.1 Step 4: Talents

Spend XP on talents. Recommended starting talents for common archetypes:

Archetype	Recommended Talents
Warrior	Weapon Master (5 XP), Effortless Charge (4 XP), Conditioning (4 XP)
Rogue	Keen Senses (2 XP), Trackless Step (2 XP), Backstab (6 XP)
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)
Runekeeper	Familiar (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)
Invoker	Patron's Symbol (4 XP)
Summoner	Pact-Whisperer (2 XP) + Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)
Support	Field Dressing (2 XP), Medic's Hand (3 XP), Inspire (3 XP)

3.8.2 Step 5: Equipment

Choose starting equipment based on concept. See Section ?? for weapon, armor, and gear tables.

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Define 1–2 mutual bonds with other player characters. Each bond gives:

- Once per session, when you act meaningfully on the bond and provide an Intricate Description, gain 1 Boon.
- Bonded allies may gift 2 Boons per scene to each other (instead of the normal 1).

A bond should include:

- A shared history or obligation.
- What each character gains from the bond.
- A potential source of tension.

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Choose 0–2 complications. Each gives +2 XP at start. Complications should be narrative hooks, not purely mechanical penalties. Examples:

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For each complication taken, at the start of each scene the GM gains +1 SB until the complication is resolved in play.

3.8.5 Step 8: Finalize

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Skills: Melee 2, Athletics 2, Endurance 1, Command 1

Talents: Weapon Master (5 XP), Conditioning (4 XP), Effortless Charge (4 XP)

Equipment: Medium weapon, medium armor

Bond: One mutual bond

Complication: None

3.9.2 Rogue (32 XP)

Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 2, Presence 2

Skills: Stealth 2, Subterfuge 2, Sway 2, Tinker 1

Talents: Keen Senses (2 XP), Silk Palms (2 XP), Backstab (6 XP)

Equipment: Light weapons, light armor, lockpicks

Bond: One mutual bond

Complication: None

3.9.3 Caster (32 XP)

Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 1

Skills: Arcana 2, Lore 2, Insight 1, Investigation 1

Talents: Spellcraft (6 XP)

Equipment: Staff, robes, focus (crystal, runestone, or inkpot)

Bond: One mutual bond

Complication: None

3.10 Advanced Start: Tier II (80 XP)

For campaigns beginning at higher power, characters may start with 80 XP. In addition to the 32 XP baseline, add:

- +2 attribute points (raise any attributes; maximum 4).
- +8 skill points (maximum skill 3 at start; raise to 4 later).
- Additional talents worth approximately 48 XP.
- One Minor Asset (4 XP) or one Follower (Cap 2).
- One additional bond or complication (narrative only; no extra XP).

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3.12 Build Point Summary

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Skill (per point)	$2 \times \text{new level}$	2
Talent	varies	—
Bond (mutual)	+1 XP each (2 total)	2
Complication	+2 XP each (2 total)	2
Minor Asset	4 XP	1
Follower (Cap 2)	2 XP	1

4 Attributes and Skills

4.1 Attributes

Every character has four attributes rated from 1 (weak) to 5 (exceptional). Attribute ratings determine the base number of dice for any action roll.

Attribute	Description
Body	Strength, endurance, and physical resilience. Used for melee combat, athletics, and resisting fatigue.
Wits	Perception, speed, and quick thinking. Used for ranged combat, stealth, and noticing details.
Spirit	Willpower, focus, and resolve. Used for magic, resisting fear, and maintaining composure.
Presence	Charisma, command, and social influence. Used for persuasion, leadership, and deception.

4.2 Skills

Skills represent specialized training or experience. Each skill is rated from 0 (untrained) to 5 (master). The skill rating is added to the relevant attribute to form the dice pool.

4.2.1 Combat Skills

Skill	Description
Melee	Swords, axes, spears, and other close-quarters weapons.
Ranged	Bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, and firearms.
Brawl	Unarmed combat, grappling, and improvised weapons.
Tactics	Battlefield strategy, unit coordination, and ambush planning.

4.2.2 Physical Skills

Skill	Description
Athletics	Running, climbing, jumping, swimming, and general physical exertion.
Stealth	Moving unseen, hiding, camouflage, and silent movement.
Endurance	Resisting fatigue, poison, harsh weather, and physical hardship.
Craft	Building, repairing, creating tools, structures, or mechanical devices.
Survival	Tracking, foraging, predicting weather, navigating wilderness, and animal handling.

4.2.3 Social Skills

Skill	Description
Sway	Persuasion, negotiation, charm, and inspiring trust or goodwill.
Command	Leadership, intimidation, issuing orders, and demanding obedience.
Deception	Lying, bluffing, misdirection, disguise, and forgery.
Performance	Singing, acting, oration, musical display, and public speaking.
Insight	Reading emotions, detecting lies, understanding motives, and social deduction.

4.2.4 Knowledge Skills

Skill	Description
Lore	History, culture, religion, customs, local knowledge, and legends.
Investigation	Research, deduction, analysis of clues, and forensic examination.
Medicine	Healing, anatomy, first aid, surgery, and treating disease or poison.

4.2.5 Magic Skills

Skill	Description
Arcana	Magic theory, identification of spells and wards, counterspelling, and free casting.
Ritual	Performing rites, invocations, exorcisms, consecrations, and structured magical workings.

4.3 Skill Uses (Common Examples)

Skill	Common Actions	Typical Difficulty
Melee	Attack with sword or axe	DV 3 (Controlled)
Ranged	Shoot a bow at Near range	DV 3
Athletics	Climb a wall, leap a gap	DV 3–4
Stealth	Hide from guards	Opposed by Perception
Survival	Track a creature, find water	DV 3–4
Sway	Persuade a guard to look away	DV 3 (varies by leverage)
Insight	Detect a lie	DV 3 (opposed by Deception)
Lore	Recall historical or cultural knowledge	DV 2–4
Investigation	Search a room for clues	DV 3–4
Medicine	Stabilize a dying ally	DV 3–5 (by severity)
Arcana	Identify a magical effect	DV 4–5
Ritual	Perform a consecration or exorcism	DV 4–6

4.4 Default Skill for Common Actions

If an action does not clearly match a listed skill, the GM may default to the most appropriate attribute alone (e.g., a raw Strength check uses Body with no skill). However, encourage players to justify skill use through their approach.

4.5 Assistance and Skill Synergy

When two characters cooperate using the same or complementary skills, the primary actor gains +1 die per assistant (up to the assist cap of +3). The GM may require each assistant to succeed on a small roll (DV 2) to provide meaningful help.

5 Talents

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. Each costs XP. Passive talents are always on; active talents require an action or reaction and cannot be used simultaneously unless noted.

5.1 Talent Costs

Cost	Category
2–3 XP	Minor edge (small bonus, once per scene).
4–6 XP	Major edge (permanent +1 die in a niche, access to magic).
7–10 XP	Prestige (campaign-defining).
11+ XP	Epic (legendary, story-shaping).

5.2 Magic Access Talents

These talents grant access to magic systems. See Section ?? for full rules.

Talent	Effect
Spellcraft (6 XP)	Enables freeform casting (Weave + Cast).
Familiar (2 XP)	Required for Patron's Gift; binds a Thiasos.
Codex (4 XP)	Required for Runekeeper Rites and Obligation tracking.
Patron's Symbol (4 XP)	Allows Invoker rituals (one per Patron).
Cantor's Path (8 XP)	Allows Songs; tracks Corruption instead of Obligation.
Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)	Base summoning access.

5.3 Striker Talents (Melee/Ranged Damage)

Talent	Effect
Weapon Master (5 XP)	+2 dice with a chosen weapon; once/scene +1 Effect with that weapon.
Flurry Strike (6 XP)	Make two attacks as one action (each -1 die). Once/scene.
Duelist's Edge (6 XP)	+1 die when engaged with a single opponent; ignore first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent once/scene.
Backstab (6 XP)	When attacking from stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of Armor. Once/scene.
Shadow Dance (10 XP)	After a successful Backstab, test Stealth to re-enter stealth; on success, clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position by 1. Once/scene.
Effortless Charge (4 XP)	Ignore the Fatigue cost of Charge once/scene.
Effortless Skirmish (4 XP)	Ignore the Fatigue cost of Skirmish once/scene.
Relentless (6 XP)	May Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies).

5.4 Defender Talents (Tank, Protection)

Talent	Effect
Defensive Survival (3 XP)	+1 to defense DV while engaged in melee; once/scene convert Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue.
Conditioning (4 XP)	Body counts as +1 for Fatigue track; +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects.
Tactical Movement (4 XP)	May move within engagement range as a Move action (instead of full action); once/scene disengage from Close as a Move action.
Stubborn Pursuer (6 XP)	When an opponent within Close range Disengages, you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range.

Note: Any character may use the *Protect* action (see Action Economy); no talent required.

5.5 Controller Talents (Area, Debuff, Terrain)

Talent	Effect
Battlefield Mastery (6 XP)	When engaged with 3+ opponents for 3 exchanges: melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at -1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue. Once/scene.
Spellcraft (6 XP)	Enables freeform spellcasting; see Section ??.
Ritual Mastery (4 XP)	Reduce casting time for major rituals by half; GM banks 1 SB on any ritual backlash.

5.6 Support Talents (Healing, Buffs, Teamwork)

Talent	Effect
Field Dressing (2 XP)	When an ally would take Harm that would incapacitate them, you may use your reaction to stabilize them; they remain at Harm 2 instead of 3 for the scene. Once/scene.
Medic's Hand (3 XP)	When you stabilize an ally, also clear 1 Fatigue or downgrade Harm 2 → 1. Spend 1 Boon to do both.
Inspire (3 XP)	Once/scene, spend 1 Boon and choose: a bonded ally gains +1 Boon and +1 die on their next roll; or all allies in Near gain +1 die on their next roll.
Command Presence (4 XP)	+1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls.
Tactical Relay (3 XP)	Once/scene, spend 1 Boon; all allies currently acting in Near gain +1 Position on their next action.

5.7 Scout Talents (Stealth, Infiltration, Awareness)

Talent	Effect
Keen Senses (2 XP)	+1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.
Trackless Step (2 XP)	Once/scene, leave no trail for the remainder of the scene.
Urban Navigation (2 XP)	Never get lost in cities.
Silk Palms (2 XP)	When you bribe or gift a minor official, gain a temporary String: <i>Bought Silence</i> . Activate it to reduce DV by 1 on a Petition or Broker action involving that official (consumed).
Camouflage (4 XP)	In natural terrain, spend an action to blend in; gain +2 dice to Stealth while remaining still; pursuers suffer -1 die to detect you. Once/scene.

5.8 Monk Talents (Unarmed Specialist)

Talent	Effect
Disciplined Body (3 XP)	+1 die to unarmed attacks; once/scene convert Harm 1 → Fatigue; once/scene improve Position by one step.
Open Hand Technique (2 XP)	On a successful unarmed attack, choose one: knock target prone, push them back one band, or force them to drop a held item. Once/scene.
Iron Fist Way (6 XP)	+1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted for harming supernatural creatures.
Flowing Spirit Way (8 XP)	Convert 1 Harm per attack to Fatigue; +1 die against fear or charm effects.
Perfect Timing Way (7 XP)	Twice per scene, improve Position by +1; +1 die to reaction rolls.

5.9 Summoning Talents

See Section ?? for full summoning rules.

Talent	Effect
Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)	Call spirits of Cap 1.
Greater Pactwright (4 XP)	Call spirits of Cap 3.
Dual Pactwright (6 XP)	May maintain one spirit of each Cap simultaneously.
Spirit Synergy (4 XP)	When maintaining two spirits simultaneously, reduce each spirit's Leash ticking by 1 (min 1).
Bonded Summoner (3 XP)	Favored spirits (Spirit Bond Timer completed) gain an additional −1 tick per command (stacks with other reductions).
Spirit Link (10 XP)	Commands are free actions; spirits act on your turn; reduce Leash ticking for natural behaviours by 1.
True Name Keeper (15 XP)	Call any previously met spirit by its true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2 (min equal to Spirit) for that summoning.
Legion Master (18 XP)	May maintain a number of spirits simultaneously equal to your Presence (minimum 2). Each spirit tracked separately.

5.10 Cantor Talents

See Section ?? for full Cantor rules.

Talent	Effect
Cantor's Path (8 XP)	Required to sing Songs; grants Corruption timer (segments = Spirit).
Resonant Rite (3 XP)	Once per session, designate a Low Rite as Resonant for your Patron. Performing it in front of witnesses may found a Chorus.
Inspire Chorus (2 XP)	While actively singing a Song, all allies within Near shift Position +1 for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled).
Repertoire (4 XP)	Track a Repertoire Timer [6]. At 2 segments, reduce base DV of all Songs by 1 (min 2). At 4 segments, +1 die to Performance rolls. At 6 segments, learn one Standard Rite as a Song.

5.11 Cooperative Talents

See Section ?? for full coordination rules.

Talent	Effect
Shield Wall (4 XP)	If you and at least one ally each wield a shield and are adjacent: as a Defend action, grant +1 die to all in the Wall and convert the first incoming Harm (any one) to Fatigue. Ends if formation breaks.
Spotter's Mark (3 XP)	Aim a target (1 action). Until end of scene or until target breaks line of sight, each PC in Near may claim +1 die or +1 Effect once vs that target. Once/scene you may spend 1 Boon to refresh the mark.
Battle Cant (2 XP)	Once/scene, establish silent signals. On the next coordinated action where at least two PCs act on the same beat, those PCs gain +1 Position. Spend 1 Boon to include a third PC.
Anchor Sigil (Runekeeper, 4 XP)	Bank 1 Boon on a prepared sigil. Once this scene, when an ally Casts or Invokes a Rite, discharge: -1 DV for that action or redirect minor backlash to you as Fatigue +1.
Exceptional Coordination+ (8 XP)	Your follower assist cap increases to +4d. If Bonded with that follower, you may split as +2d to two different allies on the same exchange.

5.12 Acquiring New Talents

- Talents are purchased with XP during downtime.
- Training time: minor talents require 3–10 days; major talents require 1–2 weeks.
- Prestige and epic talents require narrative justification (finding a master, completing a quest, Patron bargain).
- A character may retrain one talent per downtime (replace with another of equal or lesser cost). The replaced talent is lost.

6 Equipment

6.1 Weapons by Weight Class

A weapon's weight determines its Harm, its dice modifier at different ranges, and its tempo. Harm is applied directly when an attack hits; the dice modifier affects the attack roll, not damage.

Weight	Harm	Close	Near	Far	Tempo
Light	1	+2d	+1d	—	Fast
Medium	2	+1d	+2d	—	Standard
Heavy	3	−1d	+3d	+1d	Slow

6.1.1 Notes

- **Fast tempo:** You may move and attack in the same turn (Move + Action).
- **Standard tempo:** You may move or attack in a turn, not both.
- **Slow tempo:** Attacking requires a Set action (or a full turn action) before the attack; you cannot move and attack in the same turn unless a talent says otherwise.
- **Heavy weapons at Close:** Suffer −1d due to limited maneuvering room.
- A weapon cannot attack beyond its maximum listed range unless a talent or special ammunition extends it.

6.2 Ranged Weapons and Ammunition

Ranged weapons follow the same weight and tempo rules. Ammunition is tracked abstractly as part of Supply (see Section ??). A character may run low on ammunition when the GM spends SB on resource strain or during extended travel.

6.3 Armor

Armor does not reduce Harm directly. Instead, it converts incoming Harm into Fatigue. See Section ?? for the full conversion procedure.

Armor Type	Conversion	Notes
Light	1 Harm → 1 Fatigue	−1d to physical actions (optional)
Medium	2 Harm → 1 Fatigue	No penalty
Heavy	3 Harm → 2 Fatigue	−2d to physical actions; cannot sprint

6.3.1 Armor Conversion Examples

- Light armor vs Harm 1: take 1 Fatigue. No Harm.
- Medium armor vs Harm 2: take 1 Fatigue. No Harm.

- Heavy armor vs Harm 3: take 2 Fatigue. No Harm.
- Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

6.4 Shields (Optional)

Shields are worn in the off-hand. Using a shield restricts weapon size to Light or Medium.

Shield	Benefit	Tradeoff
Buckler	+1d to Defend actions once per scene	Off-hand occupied; -1d to ranged attacks
Heater	+1d to Defend actions; 1 Harm → Fatigue per scene	Off-hand occupied; -1d to ranged attacks
Pavise	Plant to create heavy cover (one direction)	Bulky; cannot move while planted

6.5 Mundane Gear

Most gear is abstracted. When you need a specific item (rope, lockpicks, torch), assume you have it unless the fiction says otherwise or the GM spends SB to declare a shortage.

The following items are tracked as part of **Supply** (see Section ??):

- | | |
|-------------------|-------------------------|
| • Rations (1 day) | • Crowbar |
| • Torches (3) | • Hammer and spikes |
| • Waterskin | • Sack (large) |
| • Rope (10m) | • Grappling hook |
| • Tinderbox | • Lantern and oil |
| • Bedroll | • Healer's kit (3 uses) |

6.6 Equipment Condition

All gear can become **Neglected** or **Compromised**.

- **Neglected:** Weapons suffer -1 die on attack rolls; armor conversion worsens by one step (e.g., Light behaves as Unarmored). Neglected gear is usable but unreliable.
- **Compromised:** Weapons suffer -1 die on the first attack each round; armor provides no conversion (all Harm applies directly). Compromised gear is barely functional.

6.6.1 Repair

- **Neglected → Functional:** Requires a short rest (1 hour) and access to basic tools.
- **Compromised → Neglected:** Requires a scene of dedicated work (Craft test, DV 3) or a visit to a smith.
- **Compromised → Functional:** Requires significant downtime (a full day) and a successful Craft test (DV 4) or a professional smith.

- Enchanted items require the same repairs; enchantments are inactive while the item is Compromised.

6.7 Magical Items (Enchantments)

Enchantments are permanent magical modifications treated as Minor or Standard Assets (see Section ??). Each enchantment costs XP and counts toward the item's enchantment limit.

6.7.1 Enchantment Limits

- Light item: maximum 1 enchantment.
- Medium item: maximum 2 enchantments.
- Heavy item: maximum 3 enchantments.

6.7.2 Sample Enchantments

- **Keen Edge (2 XP):** +1 die when attacking armored targets.
- **Flaming Blade (4 XP):** +1 Harm against creatures vulnerable to fire; +1 Effect against cold-based foes.
- **Soulfire Weapon (6 XP):** Ignores 1 point of armor or resistance.
- **Shadowweave Armor (2 XP):** +1 die to Stealth rolls while moving.
- **Runed Plate (4 XP):** Reduce magical backlash severity by one step (e.g., Moderate → Minor).
- **Boots of Sure Step (3 XP):** Ignore difficult terrain penalties.

6.7.3 Removing an Enchantment

An enchantment can be removed with a ritual (Wits + Arcana, DV 4) costing 1 XP per enchantment level. The item is not damaged.

6.8 Weapon and Armor Acquisition

- Mundane weapons and armor are acquired through play (found, looted, purchased with Supply, or granted as part of character background). No XP cost.
- Masterwork or enchanted items require XP expenditure (as Assets) or narrative quests.
- A character begins play with one Light or Medium weapon and one set of Light or Medium armor appropriate to their background.

7 Action Economy

7.1 Turn Structure

Each character takes **1 Action** and **1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order. A character may use a Boon to re-roll their action at the expense of their Move if they still have it available.

7.2 Move

- Shift one range band: Close $\leftrightarrow$ Near $\leftrightarrow$ Far.
- Reposition within the same range band (e.g., from behind one tree to another). This does not change your range band but may affect cover or line of sight.
- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.

7.3 Actions

7.3.1 Attack

Make a melee or ranged attack versus DV set by the GM and fiction. Ranged attacks made while within Close range of an enemy are Desperate (re-roll one success).

7.3.2 Disengage

Action (not a Move). You prepare to retreat safely. After taking Disengage, your Move this turn does not provoke opportunity attacks. You cannot also Attack this turn.

7.3.3 Dash

Action. Move two range bands (e.g., Close $\rightarrow$ Far). Your next defense roll is Desperate.

7.3.4 Charge (Full Turn Action)

Move up to two range bands toward an enemy and make one melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Your next defense is Desperate. Consumes both your Action and Move. Requires open ground (no difficult terrain). If your target is behind full cover, you cannot complete the Charge — you may move up to the cover and end your turn there; the attack is lost.

7.3.5 Skirmish (Full Turn Action)

Move up to two range bands away from an enemy and make one ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Your next defense is Desperate. Consumes both Action and Move. Requires open ground. If you start your turn hidden, you may Skirmish: leave cover, move, shoot, and may end your turn in

new cover if available. You are exposed during movement and the shot; opportunity attacks apply normally.

7.3.6 Observe / Change Position

Take a beat to read the field or set angles. Gain +1 Position for one action this turn (e.g., Controlled → Dominant). Limit once per turn; cannot exceed Dominant.

7.3.7 Setup (Teamwork)

Create advantage for an ally. On success, grant their next action +1 Position or step up Effect (GM's call).

7.3.8 Assist (Teamwork)

Spend 1 Boon to give an ally +1 die on their current roll. You share appropriate risk or consequence.

7.3.9 Protect

Adopt a guarding stance or body-block. Choose a nearby ally. Until your next turn, you may intercept one hit targeting them and roll to resist it. On success, reduce or negate Harm; you take any fallout the GM assigns.

7.3.10 Interact

Lift, pull, flip a lever, shove a foe, break an object, apply a poultice, reload, draw or stow a weapon, hide, or search. GM sets DV and Effect.

7.3.11 Defend

Spend your Action or Move to enter a defensive stance. Until your next turn, you count as Defending. When resisting any attack or effect, improve your Position by one step (or gain +1 die if already Dominant).

7.3.12 Free Actions

Short shouts, dropping an item, a quick glance. Longer or tactical assessments require Observe / Change Position or Interact.

7.4 Reactions (Out of Turn)

- **Opportunity Attack:** When an enemy leaves your Close range without using Disengage, you may make one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost). This does not consume

your action for the round.

- **Protection** may trigger when an ally is hit and you are in position.
- Class and asset reactions fire as written (e.g., counter-runes, ripostes).

Actions that provoke opportunity attacks when performed while engaged in Close with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] tag.

7.5 Sidestep Strike

As part of a melee attack action, you may move one range band (Close ↔ Near or Near ↔ Far) without using your Move action for the turn. If you do so, your Position for that attack worsens by one step (e.g., Controlled becomes Desperate, Dominant becomes Controlled). You cannot also use your regular Move action in the same turn.

7.6 Shove

Action. Opposed Body + Athletics vs. target's Body + Athletics. On success, push the target back one range band (Close → Near). The target suffers -1 Position on their next action.

7.7 Grapple

Action. Opposed Body + Melee vs. target's Body + Athletics. On success, both characters are engaged (cannot move apart). The grappled target suffers -1 die on all actions. Breaking free requires a new opposed roll as an action.

7.8 Hiding and Cover

- To hide, a character must be behind **full cover** (e.g., a large tree, a wall) or in heavy concealment (dense fog, darkness).
- Take the **Interact** action to hide, rolling Stealth (or appropriate skill) vs. the Perception of any observers.
- Once hidden, you are not a valid target for attacks unless an attacker first uses an action to **Search** (Perception vs. your Stealth) or you reveal yourself by attacking or moving into the open.
- If you move out of cover to attack, you are no longer hidden for the duration of the attack and may be subject to opportunity attacks if you leave an enemy's Close range.

7.9 Ready and Overwatch

Players may hold an action with a clear trigger (e.g., "I shoot the first enemy who comes through that door"). If the trigger occurs, resolve the held action before the next exchange starts.

7.10 Refresh Windows

- **Once per scene** effects reset at scene end.
- **Once per exchange** effects reset at the next beat.

7.11 Summary Table of Actions

Action	Cost	Effect
Attack	1 Action	Make melee or ranged attack.
Disengage	1 Action	Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; cannot Attack.
Dash	1 Action	Move two bands; next defense Desperate.
Charge	Full turn (Action + Move), 1 Fatigue	Move two bands toward enemy + melee attack; next defense Desperate.
Skirmish	Full turn (Action + Move), 1 Fatigue	Move two bands away + ranged attack; next defense Desperate.
Observe	1 Action	+1 Position on next action this turn.
Setup	1 Action	Grant ally +1 Position or +1 Effect.
Assist	1 Boon	Grant ally +1 die on current roll.
Protect	1 Action	Intercept one hit on nearby ally.
Interact	1 Action	Manipulate environment, hide, search, etc.
Defend	1 Action or Move	Defensive stance; +1 Position or +1 die to resist.

8 Combat

Combat uses the same core resolution loop as any other encounter: declare intent, set Position and DV, roll, apply outcome. This section provides specific rules for violence, movement, and tactical positioning.

8.1 Rhythm of Battle

Fate's Edge does not use fixed initiative. The GM spotlights characters based on the fiction, circumstances, and tension.

- **Ambushers act first.** Targets respond after the opening exchange.

- **Spotlight shifts** mid-scene if fictionally appropriate (e.g., reacting to a falling ceiling, seizing a moment).
- **Players may suggest acting** when it makes sense in the fiction.

8.2 Turn Structure

Each character’s turn consists of **1 Action** and **1 Move**. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order. Repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

8.2.1 Move

Move up to one range band (Close → Near → Far, or vice versa). You may also use your Move to reposition within the same range band (e.g., from behind one tree to another at the same distance). This does not change your range band but may affect cover or line of sight.

- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.
- **Dash (Action):** Gain an extra Move. You may move two bands total in your turn. Your next defense roll is Desperate.

8.2.2 Disengage (Action)

Prepare to retreat safely. After taking Disengage, your Move this turn does not provoke opportunity attacks. You cannot also Attack this turn.

8.3 Range Bands

Band	Default	Notes
Close	Touching	Melee reach; grapples, knives, short weapons.
Near	Same room/street segment	Thrown weapons, short bows, most magic.
Far	Distant (same site)	Long bows, line spells; needs time or route to close.
Absent	Off-screen	Outside scene frame; needs travel or cut to interact.

8.4 Melee Flag

Two parties are “in Melee” when they are within Near and directly engaged.

- **Enter Melee:** 1 Move from Near (Controlled if under fire).
- **Leave Melee:** 1 Move to break off. If threatened, you must take the **Disengage** action. Without Disengage, leaving Close range provokes a free opportunity attack.

8.5 Opportunity Attacks

Moving out of an enemy's Close range without using the Disengage action provokes one free melee attack from that enemy. The attack is resolved normally (Position usually Controlled) and does not consume the enemy's action for the round.

Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while engaged in Close with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] tag.

8.6 Full Turn Actions

8.6.1 Charge

Move up to two range bands toward an enemy (e.g., Far → Near → Close) and make one melee attack.

- Costs 1 Fatigue.
- Your next defense is Desperate.
- Consumes both your Action and Move.
- Requires open ground (no difficult terrain) unless you have a talent that overrides this.
- If your target is hidden behind full cover, you cannot complete the Charge. You may move up to the cover and end your turn there; the attack is lost.

8.6.2 Skirmish

Move up to two range bands away from an enemy and make one ranged attack.

- Costs 1 Fatigue.
- Your next defense is Desperate.
- Consumes both your Action and Move.
- Requires open ground.
- If you start your turn hidden, you may Skirmish: leave cover, move, shoot, and may end your turn in new cover if available. You are exposed during movement and the shot; opportunity attacks apply normally.

8.7 Cover and Hiding

8.7.1 Cover

- **Partial cover:** +1 DV to target you.

- **Full cover:** You cannot be targeted directly.

8.7.2 Hiding

To hide, a character must be behind full cover or in heavy concealment (dense fog, darkness). Take the **Interact** action to hide, rolling Stealth (or appropriate skill) against the Perception of any observers.

- Once hidden, you are not a valid target unless an attacker first uses an action to **Search** (Perception vs. your Stealth) or you reveal yourself.
- Revealing yourself by attacking or moving into the open ends the hidden state. You are exposed for the duration of the attack and may provoke opportunity attacks if you leave an enemy's Close range.

8.8 Height Advantage

Attacking from higher ground (e.g., a ledge, rooftop, or horse) grants +1 die or +1 Effect (GM's choice).

8.9 Difficult Terrain

- Costs 2 Move actions to traverse one band (or a full action to Dash).
- Charge and Skirmish require open ground unless the character has the **Relentless** talent.

8.10 Mounted Combat (Simplified)

If you have a War Mount and the **Cavalier** talent (or equivalent):

- **Charging** into melee from Far → Near: +2 dice.
- **Firing while disengaging** Near → Far: +2 dice.

The bonus applies only when movement is part of the action. Misses and Partial hits often cost mount Fatigue, equipment damage, or narrative complications.

8.11 Combat Action Options

In addition to standard actions (Attack, Disengage, Dash), characters may take:

- **Shove (Action):** Opposed Body + Athletics vs. target's Body + Athletics. On success, push the target back one range band (Close → Near). The target suffers -1 Position on their next action.
- **Grapple (Action):** Opposed Body + Melee vs. target's Body + Athletics. On success, both characters are engaged (cannot move apart). The grappled target suffers -1 die on all actions. Breaking free requires a new opposed roll as an action.

- **Protect (Action):** Adopt a guarding stance. Choose a nearby ally; until your next turn you may intercept one hit on them and roll to resist it. On success, reduce or negate Harm; you take any fallout the GM assigns.
- **Setup (Action):** Create advantage for an ally. On a success (appropriate roll, DV set by GM), grant their next action +1 Position or step up Effect.
- **Defend (Action or Move):** Enter a defensive stance. Until your next turn, improve your Position by one step when resisting any attack or effect (or gain +1 die if already Dominant).

8.12 Default Combat Assumptions

To keep play moving, the GM may assume:

- Default range = Near.
- Default Position = Controlled.
- Default Effect = Standard.
- Move one band per Move action unless terrain or fiction says otherwise.

8.13 Example: Melee Exchange

Thane charges a goblin archer.

- Thane declares **Charge** (Far → Near → Close). Costs 1 Fatigue.
- GM: “Controlled, DV 3. On a Miss, the goblin gets a parting shot.”
- Thane rolls Body 3 + Melee 3 = 6 dice: 9, 7, 6, 4, 2, 1 → 3 successes vs DV 3. Clean Success.
- Thane deals his weapon’s Harm (Medium weapon = Harm 2). The goblin is injured.
- Thane’s next defense is Desperate due to Charge.

8.14 Integration with Fatigue and Harm

Combat frequently marks Fatigue (from Charge, Skirmish, and enemy abilities) and Harm (from successful attacks). See Section ?? for recovery and the armor conversion table.

9 Health, Fatigue, and Harm

9.1 Fatigue Track

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute (minimum 1). Fatigue represents exertion, strain, and the accumulation of minor physical toll.

Marking Fatigue: Mark Fatigue for the following:

- Performing a **Charge** or **Skirmish** action (1 Fatigue).

- Forced marches, extreme effort, or environmental strain (GM discretion).
- Magical costs (e.g., Pushing a Rite, Backlash, Obligation overflow).
- Converting a Boon effect to Fatigue (substitution rule).

9.2 Effect of Fatigue

Each point of Fatigue worsens your **Position** by one step:

Dominant → Controlled → Desperate

If you are already at **Desperate Position**, each additional point of Fatigue instead imposes a **–1 die penalty** on all your rolls (cumulative).

9.3 Harm Levels

Harm represents serious injury. There are three levels:

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	–1 die on actions directly related to the injury (GM discretion).
Harm 2	–1 die on most actions until treated.
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying (cannot act; requires stabilization).

9.4 Taking Harm and Fatigue — The Procedure

When you take Harm from an attack, hazard, or magical backlash, resolve in the following order:

1. **Convert.** Use the *Armor Conversion Table* to turn incoming Harm into Fatigue. Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.
2. **Apply remaining Harm.** If any Harm remains after conversion:
 - Clear **all existing Fatigue** (the shock of a wound resets exhaustion).
 - Increase your Harm level by the number of Harm points remaining.
3. **Add Fatigue.** Add the Fatigue from step 1 to your Fatigue track.
4. **Check for Overflow.** If your Fatigue total equals or exceeds your Body (track size):
 - Increase Harm by one level.
 - Clear all Fatigue.
 - Any excess Fatigue beyond the track size is lost.

Overflow can occur multiple times from a single hit (e.g., with Body 1 or 2).

9.5 Armor Conversion Table

Armor does not reduce incoming Harm directly. Instead, it converts Harm to Fatigue according to the table below.

Armor Type	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Example: Light armor vs Harm 2 becomes *Harm 1 + Fatigue 1*. Heavy armor vs Harm 3 becomes *Fatigue 2*.

9.6 Recovery

9.6.1 Fatigue Recovery

- **Short rest** (1 hour): Remove 2 Fatigue.
- **Full night's rest** (8 hours): Remove all Fatigue.

9.6.2 Harm Recovery

- **Medical care:** A successful Medicine roll (DV 3–5, depending on severity) can reduce Harm by one level after a scene of treatment. A critical success may remove two levels.
- **Magical healing:** A [HEAL] spell or Rite can reduce Harm by one level (see Magic system).
- **Natural recovery:** Without medical or magical aid, one level of Harm heals after one week of rest. Harm 3 requires intervention.

9.7 Substituting Fatigue for Boons

If you have no Boons remaining (or wish to conserve them), you may pay 1 Fatigue in place of 1 Boon to activate any effect that normally costs a Boon. The GM may veto this substitution if the fiction makes it implausible (e.g., activating a delicate Asset while exhausted). This does not change the effect's outcome; it merely changes the resource spent.

9.8 Example: Armor and Overflow

Heavy armor, Body 2, currently Fatigue 1, Harm 0. Hit with Harm 3.

1. Convert: Harm 3 $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 2 (from table).
2. Apply remaining Harm: 0 remaining (all converted). No Harm applied, no Fatigue cleared.
3. Add Fatigue: 1 (current) + 2 = 3. Track size is 2 $\rightarrow$ overflow.

4. Overflow: Harm 0 → 1. Clear all Fatigue. Excess lost.
5. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 0.

9.9 Death and Dying

At **Harm 3**, a character is incapacitated. They cannot take actions. They may still speak weakly or crawl at the GM’s discretion.

9.9.1 Stabilization

- An ally may use an action to stabilize the dying character with a successful Medicine roll (DV 3). On success, the character remains at Harm 3 but is stable (no further deterioration).
- Without stabilization, the character will die at the end of the scene unless circumstances change (e.g., magical healing, arrival of a skilled healer).

9.9.2 Raising Harm Above 3

If a character at Harm 3 takes additional Harm, they die immediately. Resurrection or miraculous recovery is possible only through major rituals, Patron intervention, or narrative circumstances (GM discretion).

10 Magic System

Magic in Fate’s Edge is expressed through four interconnected paths. Each uses the same core resolution engine (Position, DV, Boons, SB) but manages risk differently.

- **Caster (Freeform):** Flexible, improvisational magic. Risk of Backlash.
- **Runekeeper (Rites):** Structured magic through a Patron’s Codex. Risk of Obligation.
- **Invoker (Symbols):** Ritual magic through consecrated Symbols. Slow but safe; can be forced.
- **Cantor (Songs):** Perform Low Rites as songs. Risk of Corruption.

10.1 The Four Paths at a Glance

Path	Prerequisite	Roll Skill	Risk Track	Speed
Caster	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Arcana	Backlash (1s)	2 actions (1 for
Runekeeper	Familiar + Codex	Ritual	Obligation (per Rite)	1 action
Invoker	Patron’s Symbol	Ritual	Obligation + Symbol damage	Ritual (slow) or in
Cantor	Cantor’s Path (8 XP)	Performance + Lore	Corruption (Spirit-based timer)	1 action (resolves

10.2 Caster (Freeform / Weave & Cast)

Free casters shape raw magic by combining elements and effects. They are flexible but unpredictable.

10.2.1 Requirements

- **Spellcraft (6 XP):** Required for Weave & Cast freeform magic.

10.2.2 Procedure

1. **Weave (Action):** Describe the spell and choose its tags (see Section ??).
2. **Cast (Action):** Roll Attribute (usually Wits or Spirit) + Arcana. The GM sets DV based on the tags.

Cantrip: A spell with a single tag can be cast as a Cantrip: one roll, standard action, no Weave phase. Cannot bypass wards or create large-scale effects.

10.2.3 Spell DV

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of tags}$$

Dangerous tags ([FOLD], [GATE], [LEAP], [CREATE], [SUMMON], [TRANSMUTE], [ANIMATE], [TRANSFORM], [DOMINATE], [REWIND]) add +2 DV each instead of +1.

10.2.4 Backlash

On a Partial or Miss, or on a Hit that shows two or more 1s, the GM applies backlash colored by the dominant element(s). See Section ?? for details.

10.3 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind structured magic through a Codex and a Thiasos (familiar spirit). They specialize in reliable, thematic magic.

10.3.1 Requirements

- **Bond to a single Patron.**
- **Thiasos (Familiar talent, 2 XP):** Enables Patron's Gift.
- **Codex (4 XP):** Grants access to the Patron's Rites and starts the Obligation ledger.

10.3.2 Invoking a Rite

1. Declare the Rite (1 action).
2. Mark the Rite's Obligation cost (listed in the rite description, e.g., **Obligation: 6 segments**).
3. If the Rite calls for a roll, roll Attribute + Ritual. The GM sets DV using the formula:

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Rite Tier})$$

where Rite Tier is 1 for Low, 2 for Standard, 3 for High/Epic.

Push It: Mark +1 additional Obligation to increase duration, range, or potency.

10.3.3 Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Requires Thiasos. Once per scene as 1 action, imbue a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic Skill (determined by your Patron) for the scene. Push It to extend one additional scene (+1 Obligation).

10.4 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers channel power through consecrated Symbols. Rituals are slow but safe; Crack the Seal offers desperate speed.

10.4.1 Requirements

- **One or more Patron's Symbols (4 XP each).** Each Symbol is a Minor Asset.

10.4.2 Ritual Invocation

1. Display the Symbol (must be visible).
2. Perform the Rite. Takes $DV + 1$ rounds (Significant Time), where DV is calculated as above.
3. Mark the Rite's Obligation cost (listed).
4. If the Symbol is displayed openly during the ritual, reduce the Obligation cost by 1 (minimum 0).

10.4.3 Crack the Seal (Instant Cast)

1. Invoke the Rite as 1 action (instead of ritual time).
2. Mark double the Rite's Obligation cost (or +2 minimum, +3 for High Rites if the base cost is unclear).
3. The Symbol becomes **Compromised** (inert). Restore it during downtime (Arcana or Lore test, DV 3) or pay 1 XP.

10.4.4 Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Once per scene, spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue (1 action) to gain +1 die on a combat action, or +1 Effect on a social or stealth action. Requires visibly displaying your Patron's Symbol. If the Symbol is Compromised, Borrowed Grace works at -1 die.

10.5 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs, channeling power through voice and performance. They track Corruption instead of Obligation.

10.5.1 Requirements

- **Cantor's Path (8 XP).**
- **Performance 2+, Lore 1+, Presence 2+.**

10.5.2 Singing a Song

1. Begin the Song (1 action). It resolves at the start of your next turn.
2. Roll Lore + Performance vs DV (typically 2-3).
3. On success, the Low Rite effect occurs. No Obligation cost.
4. Mark Corruption accumulation (see below).

10.5.3 Push It

Resolve the Song immediately (instead of next turn). Mark 1 Fatigue and advance your Corruption Timer by 1 segment.

10.5.4 Corruption Timer

Your Corruption Timer has segments equal to your Spirit attribute. Mark a segment when you:

- Push a Song.
- Perform a Resonant Rite (a powerful thematic working designated by your Patron).
- The GM spends a Story Beat on your occult activities.

When the timer fills, you immediately gain a thematic boon and burden from the last Patron whose Rite you performed. Then reset the timer to zero (cannot go below your current Tier -1 -1).

10.5.5 Cantor Corruption Examples (The Eight Core Patrons)

When a Cantor's Corruption Timer fills, they immediately gain a thematic **boon** (benefit) and **burden** (drawback) from the last Patron whose Rite they performed. The timer resets to zero, but the mark of Corruption remains—a permanent change to the character's voice, manner, or soul.

The examples below are for the eight patrons recommended for first characters. The GM and player should collaborate to create blooms that fit the fiction.

@p3.2cmp4.8cmp4.8cm@

Patron Boon (Benefit) Burden (Drawback)

Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Beacon's Gaze: Your eyes gleam with dawnlight. Once knowingly tell a lie. Attempt-per session, you may force a creature to speak truth- and the words burn in your fully to one question (Resist throat. DV 4).

The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Road's Memory: You can never be lost on a path you have walked before. +1 die to Navigation rolls on familiar routes.
Restless Feet: You cannot stay in one settlement for more than a week without marking 1 Fatigue. The road calls, and you must answer.

Inaea (Angel of the Spider)

Thread-Sight: You can perceive the emotional bonds between any two people within Near range (hostility, loyalty, love, debt). The GM describes what you see.
Tangled: You cannot ignore a plea for help from someone you have previously aided. Refusing costs 1 Fatigue and haunts your dreams.

The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Unblinking: You instantly recognize when someone is lying to you. No roll required.
Cannot Look Away: You must correct any falsehood you hear, even if doing so is dangerous or socially ruinous. Remaining silent costs 1 Fatigue.

Carrion King (Decay & Renewal)

Rot's Harvest: You can sense organic matter in decay within Near range. +1 die to Survival rolls involving scavenging or foraging.
Compost-Stained: A faint scent of turned earth follows you. Animals are nervous around you (–1 die to Animal Handling), and you cannot enter consecrated ground without marking 1 Fatigue.

Ikasha (She Who Sleeps)	<i>Shadow's Daughter:</i> In dim light or darkness, you may reroll one failed Stealth roll per scene. <i>Unseen, Unheard:</i> Your voice is barely above a whisper. Anyone trying to hear you outside of Close range suffers -1 die to Perception checks involving sound.
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Grimmir (The Old Man of the Forest)	<i>Season's Tongue:</i> You instinctively know the weather for the next 24 hours and gain +1 die to all Survival rolls in natural terrain. <i>Bark-Skinned:</i> Your skin grows rough and moss-flecked. the next 24 hours and gain -1 die to social rolls in civilized settings; you are visibly <i>wild</i> .
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Palinode (Queen of Encores)	<i>Perfect Phrase:</i> Once per session, you may reroll any failed Performance or Sway roll. The second result stands. <i>Unfinished:</i> You cannot leave a performance incomplete. If you begin singing, playing, or speaking in public, you must finish or mark 1 Fatigue.
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Designer's Note: These blooms are intended to be *dramatic*, not punishing. A Corruption bloom should feel like a power surge with an interesting complication—not a penalty that discourages play. When a Cantor's timer fills, celebrate the transformation. The burden is a story hook, not a tax.

10.5.6 Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, while actively singing a Song, all allies within Near range shift Position +1 for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled).

10.6 Obligation (Runekeepers and Invokers)

Obligation measures a Patron's claim on a character. Track it per Patron. The default Obligation capacity is:

$$\text{Capacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

10.6.1 Marking Obligation

Obligation is marked according to the specific Rite or action:

- Invoking a Rite (Runekeeper or Invoker): mark the Rite's listed Obligation cost (e.g., **Obligation: 6**).
- Pushing a Rite: mark +1 additional Obligation (added to the Rite's base cost).
- Crack the Seal: mark double the Rite's base cost (or +2 minimum, +3 for High Rites).

- Using Rites from two different Patrons in the same scene: mark +1 Obligation to the second Patron.

10.6.2 Overflow

If your total Obligation (across all Patrons) exceeds your Capacity:

- Mark 1 Fatigue per segment over Capacity.
- You cannot invoke new Rites or perform Patron rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.

10.6.3 Clearing Obligation

- **Off-screen:** Perform an Act of Service aligned with the Patron (provide an Intricate Description). Clear 1 segment of that Patron's Obligation.
- **On-screen (Focused Devotion talent, 3–5 XP):** Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 segment (cannot clear segments accrued in the same scene).

10.7 Backlash (Free Casting)

Backlash is the unpredictable fallout from shaping raw magic. It occurs on a Partial or Miss, or on a Hit that shows two or more 1s.

10.7.1 Backlash Menu (choose one on Partial, two on Miss)

- **Position Shift:** Your Position worsens by one step for your current or next action.
- **Fleeting Harm/Condition:** Minor injury (1 Fatigue or Harm 1) or a temporary Condition (Dazed, Singed, Disoriented).
- **Exposure/Noise:** Draws unwanted attention — guards alerted, a door slams, a rival notices.
- **Resource Drain:** Lose a component, a tool wears out, or mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Collateral Spark:** A nearby ally, object, or environmental feature is threatened (GM describes).

All backlash is colored by the dominant element(s) used in the spell. See the Elemental Backlash table in Section ??.

10.8 Obligation Capacity and Overflow Summary

$$\text{Capacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

- **Exceeding Capacity:** Mark 1 Fatigue per segment over. Cannot invoke new Rites or perform Patron rituals until reduced.

- **Clearing:** Act of Service (off-screen, 1 segment) or Focused Devotion talent (on-screen, 1 Boon per segment).

10.9 Corruption Timer Summary (Cantor)

Timer Size = Spirit

- Mark a segment when you Push a Song, perform a Resonant Rite, or when the GM spends SB on your occult activities.
- When full: gain a thematic boon and burden from your last Patron; reset timer to zero.

11 Tags & Effects Library

Tags are keywords that define the mechanical and narrative behavior of spells, rites, talents, and assets. They do nothing on their own; they only function when granted by a rule (Spell, Rite, Talent, Ability). Unless noted otherwise, the Duration of a tag effect is **Scene**, and the DV for contests or resistances is set by the fiction (typical range 2–5).

11.1 The Eight Elements

Every spell or magical effect is built from one or more of the eight fundamental elements. The first four are physical; the second four are metaphysical.

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Element	Domain	Typical Backlash
Air	Movement, sound, wind, speed	Scatter, vertigo, deafening gusts
Fire	Energy, destruction, light, passion	Burns, smoke, uncontrolled blaze
Earth	Solidity, stone, metal, endurance	Rubble, heavy footing, tremors
Water	Fluidity, healing, cold, emotion	Flood, slippery ground, dampness
Fortune	Chance, luck, unpredictability	Random mishap, fragile success
Life	Vitality, growth, healing, nature	Overgrowth, fever, parasitic plants
Fate	Destiny, inevitability, causality	Options close, fixed outcome
Death/Dreams (Obishaal)	Endings, sleep, thresholds, memory	Whispers, numbness, threshold shifts

11.2 Effect Tags

Effect tags describe what the magic does. They are combined with element tags to form spells.

Common Effect Tags:

AREA	CLEANSE
BANISH	COMMAND
BARRIER	CONJURE
BIND	COUNTER

CURSE	REPAIR
DEFEND	REVEAL
DISPEL	SANCTIFY
FORTIFY	SEAL / [UNSEAL]
HEAL	STRIKE
MARK	TRANSPORT
MEND	VEIL
OATH	WARD
PASSAGE	

11.3 Building a Spell

A spell is a combination of one or more element tags and one or more effect tags. The base Difficulty Value is:

$$DV = 1 + \text{total number of tags (element + effect)}$$

11.3.1 Dangerous Tags

Some effects are so powerful that each dangerous tag adds +2 DV instead of +1. Dangerous tags include: [GATE], [FOLD], [LEAP], [CREATE], [SUMMON], [TRANSMUTE], [ANIMATE], [TRANSFORM], [DOMINATE], [REWIND].

11.3.2 Stacking Identical Effect Tags

You may include the same effect tag multiple times to increase its potency. Each additional copy adds its normal DV cost. Example:

- [AIR] [DEFEND] – 2 tags → DV 3. Grants +1 die to one defense roll.
- [AIR] [DEFEND] [DEFEND] – 3 tags → DV 4. Grants +2 dice to one defense roll.

Stacking is limited by the caster's Tier (max 3 copies per effect at Tier III, 4 at Tier V).

11.4 Example Spells

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Name	Tags	Effect
Light (Cantrip)	[FIRE][ILLUMINATE]	DV 3, one roll. Creates small, sustained light.
Shield of Air	[AIR][DEFEND]	DV 3, one action. +1 die to next defense roll.
Double Shield	[AIR][DEFEND][DEFEND]	DV 4, one action. +2 dice to next defense roll.
Flame Cloak	[FIRE][AREA][DEFEND]	DV 4, two actions. Enemies -1 die to approach; caster +1 to defense.
Healing Touch	[LIFE][HEAL]	DV 3, one action. Removes 1 Fatigue from touched.
Mend Wound	[LIFE][HEAL][HEAL]	DV 4, one action (or scene). Removes 2 Fatigue, or downgrades.
Teleport (Self)	[AIR][FOLD]	[FOLD] dangerous (+2). DV = 1+1+2 = 4. Teleport self with.

11.5 Repair & Restoration

Two tags handle mending objects: [MEND] for quick, temporary fixes in the field, and [REPAIR] for thorough, lasting restoration.

11.5.1 [MEND] (Quick Fix)

Restore a damaged object to functioning order for the duration of the scene.

- **DV:** by fiction (severity of damage, size, material). Typical DV 2–4.
- **Hit:** Remove one level of *Neglected* or *Compromised* from a single item for the rest of the scene. The item works normally.
- **Partial:** The item functions for the scene but becomes *Neglected* (or worsens one step) when the scene ends.
- **Miss:** No repair; the item may become *Compromised* or break (GM discretion).
- **Duration:** Scene. After the scene, the damage returns (or worsens) unless followed by a proper [REPAIR] during downtime.

Example: A snapped bowstring is magically re-knotted for the remainder of the fight; the next day it frays again.

11.5.2 [REPAIR] (Permanent Fix)

Fully restore a damaged object, tool, or piece of equipment.

- **DV:** by fiction (severity, material, magical nature). Typical DV 3–5. Magical items add +1 DV.
- **Time:** One downtime action (a few hours of focused work). Can be used during a scene only if the caster has Significant Time and appropriate tools.
- **Hit:** Remove all levels of *Neglected* and *Compromised* from a single item. The item is restored to full function.

- **Partial:** Remove one level of damage (e.g., *Compromised* → *Neglected*), or the item becomes *Neglected* but usable.
- **Miss:** No repair; the item may become *Compromised* or gain a new flaw (GM discretion).

Example: A shattered shield is reforged overnight; a rusted lock is cleaned and oiled to working order.

11.6 Influence Over Mortals

These tags affect the minds and loyalties of living beings. Using them to alter free will carries narrative and ethical consequences.

11.6.1 [BOND]

Strengthen or create a positive emotional tie between a target and a person, place, or ideal.

- **DV:** by fiction (target's current loyalty, resistance to magic). Typical DV 3–5.
- **Hit:** Increase a follower's *Loyalty* state by one step (e.g., *Strained* → *Faithful*). The target genuinely feels the bond.
- **Partial:** The bond forms but is fragile; any subsequent external pressure may break it (GM may downgrade loyalty on a future setback).
- **Miss:** No effect; the target may become suspicious or resistant to further magical influence.
- **Ethical note:** Forcing loyalty removes agency. The GM may rule that such magic is taboo, attracts Patron attention, or creates hidden complications (e.g., the follower secretly resents the caster).

Example: A Runekeeper of Inaea weaves a [BOND] rite to mend a hireling's shaken trust after a failed mission.

11.6.2 [SUBVERT]

Coerce obedience or twist existing loyalties.

- **Dangerous tag:** adds +2 DV.
- **DV:** by fiction (target's will, opposing magic). Typical DV 5–7.
- **Hit:** The target follows one simple command or shifts loyalty one step in the caster's favor (e.g., *Faithful* → *Strained* toward their original master). The effect lasts one scene or until the command is fulfilled.
- **Partial:** The target hesitates, reveals information, or acts with clear reluctance; the compulsion is visible to observers.
- **Miss:** The target resists; the caster marks 1 Fatigue and the target's original loyalty increases by one step (they become more devoted to their original cause).

- **Backlash:** On any roll showing two or more 1s, the GM may impose a *Patron's Disfavor* or a *Scandal* timer (the act becomes known).

Example: A desperate Invoker of Maelstraeus uses [SUBVERT] to force a gate guard to look away. The guard later testifies under oath, and a bounty appears.

11.7 Control & Countermagic

11.7.1 [DISPEL]

End an ongoing magical effect or construct.

- **DV:** by fiction (usually equal to the effect's Tier or casting DV).
- **Hit:** Effect ends or is suppressed per source text.
- **Partial:** Effect suppressed briefly (one exchange) or reduced in scope.
- **Miss:** No effect; GM may gain SB.

11.7.2 [COUNTER]

Interrupt a spell, rite, or ritual in progress.

- **Timing:** During the casting window (declared action or ritual phase).
- **DV:** by fiction (complexity of the interrupted effect).
- **Hit:** Cancel the action; resources used are lost.
- **Partial:** Worsen the caster's Position or impose Fatigue.
- **Miss:** No interruption; GM may spend SB to escalate.

11.7.3 [BARRIER]

Create cover, obstruction, or a physical wall.

- **DV:** by fiction (size, material, duration).
- **Hit:** Place a barrier with Integrity Timer [2/4/6]; blocks movement/attacks until cracked.
- **Partial:** Barrier is fragile or has a gap.
- **Countered by:** [DISPEL], brute force (Athletics), or clever route.

11.7.4 [SEAL] / [UNSEAL]

Magically lock or unlock a container, door, or portal (not spirits).

- **DV:** by fiction (quality of lock, magical binding).
- **Hit:** Locked/unlocked as intended; specify any bypass conditions.

- **Partial:** Seal is temporary or leaks (can be forced open with +1 DV).

11.8 Concealment & Revelation

11.8.1 [VEIL]

Obscure a person, object, or zone.

- **DV:** by fiction (scale, conditions).
- **Hit:** Impose −1 die to Notice or perception rolls against the veiled subject; specify limits (angle, distance, scent).
- **Partial:** Works only at a limited range or in dim light.
- **Countered by:** [REVEAL], strong light, physical proof.

11.8.2 [REVEAL]

Expose illusions, disguises, or hidden clauses.

- **DV:** by fiction (complexity of the concealment).
- **Hit:** Surface the truth; describe how the revelation manifests (brief glow, visible flaw, etc.).
- **Partial:** A tell or clue, not the full picture.

11.8.3 [MARK]

Tag a target for tracking or leverage.

- **DV:** by fiction (resistance, visibility).
- **Hit:** Place a visible or invisible mark; once per scene, you or an ally gain +1 die when acting directly against the Marked target.
- **Partial:** Mark is noisy or short-lived.
- **Countered by:** [CLEANSE], [DISPEL], or listed materials (salt, iron).

11.9 Boons & Burdens

11.9.1 [CURSE]

Inflict a sticky hindrance with a clear release condition.

- **DV:** by fiction (severity, target's resilience).
- **Hit:** Apply a named Condition (e.g., Shaken, Weakened) that persists until the release condition is met.
- **Partial:** Condition is milder or intermittent.

- **Countered by:** [CLEANSE] or the listed key (apology, theft return, pilgrimage).

11.9.2 [CLEANSE]

Remove or suppress a Condition (poison, disease, curse, fear).

- **DV:** by fiction (potency of the affliction).
- **Hit:** Remove one named Condition.
- **Partial:** Suppress or reduce severity for the scene.

11.9.3 [FORTIFY]

Harden a person, place, or object against a specific vector (fire, blades, fear, persuasion).

- **DV:** by fiction (scale, strength).
- **Hit:** Raise Position by one step or reduce consequence severity for attacks of that vector this scene.
- **Partial:** Limited scope (one ally, one doorway).

11.10 Influence & Oaths

11.10.1 [COMMAND]

Issue a clear order to a sapient target.

- **DV:** by fiction (authority, leverage, fear, ritual standing).
- **Hit:** Target complies now or suffers an immediate cost stated by the GM.
- **Partial:** Target hesitates, bargains, or partially complies.
- **Miss:** Refusal or blowback (GM may spend SB).

11.10.2 [OATH]

Bind parties to terms; breaking has teeth.

- **DV:** by fiction (witnesses, sanctity, stakes).
- **Hit:** Enforceable pact with stated boon for keeping and consequence for breaking.
- **Partial:** A loophole exists in the oath.
- **Countered by:** Release clause, [CLEANSE] if text allows.

11.10.3 [SANCTIFY]

Consecrate a zone to a code or Patron.

- **DV:** by fiction (size, opposition).
- **Hit:** Specify allowed/prohibited acts; violations start at Controlled Position or impose a soft consequence.
- **Partial:** Patchy coverage (e.g., only the altar, not the whole room).
- **Countered by:** Opposing rite, profanation (bloodshed, lies), time.

11.11 Movement & Making

11.11.1 [PASSAGE]

Declare a route as permitted or easy.

- **DV:** by fiction (length, danger).
- **Hit:** Allies on that path gain improved flow (+1 Position or ignore one level of difficult terrain).
- **Partial:** Only one ally or one segment benefits.

11.11.2 [TRANSPORT]

Move a target across an obstacle (blink, lift, pull).

- **DV:** by fiction (mass, range, warding).
- **Hit:** Relocate within listed range; state any tells or costs (SB, Fatigue).
- **Partial:** Arrive off-balance, drop gear, or suffer worse Position.

11.11.3 [CONJURE]

Create a useful object, cover, or hazard.

- **DV:** by fiction (size, complexity).
- **Hit:** Conjure an item or zone with Integrity Timer [2/4/6] (if destructible) or a ticking hazard (burn, freeze, haze).
- **Partial:** Fragile or short-lived (lasts one exchange).
- **Countered by:** [DISPEL], force, time.

11.12 Knowledge, Movement & Transformation

11.12.1 [TRUTH]

Ask the GM one yes/no or short-answer question about the present situation. The GM answers truthfully.

- **Hit:** Full, clear answer.
- **Partial:** Cryptic or incomplete answer (still true).
- **Miss:** No answer; GM gains 1 SB.

11.12.2 [SECRET]

Reveal a deeply hidden fact about a person, place, or object – something the target actively conceals.

- **Contest:** Spirit+Lore vs. target's Spirit+Resolve (DV 4 for passive secrets).
- **Hit:** GM reveals the secret.
- **Partial:** A clue or hint toward the secret.
- **Miss:** No information; the secret becomes harder to find (+1 DV next time).

11.12.3 [READ]

Sense the target's current dominant emotion or a single surface thought. No roll required; narrative permission only. Cannot read deep secrets or memories.

11.12.4 [OMEN]

Glimpse a likely future tied to a specific action or decision.

- **Hit:** GM gives a cryptic warning (one sentence). You may reroll one die later this session if it relates to the omen.
- **Partial:** Omen is vague; no reroll.
- **Miss:** False omen; GM may spend 1 SB to make you act on misinformation.

11.12.5 [LIBERATE]

Automatically succeed on one attempt to escape mundane physical restraints (ropes, manacles, grapple). Magical restraints require a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 4) instead.

11.12.6 [BOOST]

Gain +1 die on a single related roll, or clear 1 Fatigue. This tag does nothing on its own; the spell description must state which benefit applies.

11.12.7 [TRANSFORM]

Take on a new form for the scene. Choose one benefit:

- +1 Armor
- +1 die to a specific skill (e.g., Stealth, Athletics)
- A minor supernatural ability (e.g., flight for one exchange, water breathing, claws that deal +1 Harm)

Partial: You gain the benefit but mark 1 Fatigue when the scene ends. **Miss:** No transformation; you mark 1 Fatigue.

11.12.8 [ERASURE] (Multi-Mode)

Choose one of the following when you cast:

- *Annihilate:* Destroy a single mundane object (size chest). Magical objects resist with a [DISPEL] test (DV 4).
- *Oblivion:* Erase a specific memory from a living target. Contest Spirit+Resolve (DV 4). On a Miss, you forget instead.
- *Nullify:* Void a formal debt, oath, or contract. Requires the original document or a witnessed recitation.

11.12.9 [PRESSURE]

All enemies within the affected zone suffer −1 die to physical actions (attacks, Athletics, etc.) for the duration.

11.12.10 [DREAM]

Enter a trance or dream state. Ask the GM one question about a past event or a possible future; the answer is always cryptic (one sentence). On a Hit, you may also ignore the first Fatigue from sleep deprivation this scene.

11.12.11 [TIME]

Alter the flow of time in a small zone (Near range). Choose one:

- *Slow:* Enemies act at Desperate Position for one exchange.
- *Haste:* Allies gain +1 band of movement this turn.

Dangerous tag: '[TIME]' adds +2 DV when used to rewind or stop time completely (GM discretion).

11.12.12 [THRESHOLD]

Interact with a boundary – door, gate, portal, or conceptual threshold (e.g., between life and death).

- **Hit:** You may open, close, or pass through a mundane threshold effortlessly. A magical threshold requires a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 4).
- **Partial:** The threshold resists; you cross but mark 1 Fatigue.

11.12.13 [BURDEN]

Take a Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed, Fear) or 1 Fatigue from an ally onto yourself. The ally is freed from that affliction. Cannot transfer Harm directly.

11.13 Outsider-Specific Tags

11.13.1 [WARD]

Challenge Outsiders crossing a warded edge or zone.

- **DV = target Cap.** (Cap is the Outsider's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater.)
- **Hit:** Crosses; add +DV segments to its Leash.
- **Partial:** Crosses; add +1 segment.
- **Miss:** Cannot cross this beat.

11.13.2 [BANISH]

Drive a visible Outsider toward departure.

- **DV = target Cap.**
- **Hit:** Add +DV to its Leash.
- **Partial:** Add +1.
- **Miss:** No effect.

11.13.3 [UNWARD]

Unmake or suppress a [WARD] created by a Talent, Ability, or Spell.

- **DV:** by fiction (strength of the ward).
- **Hit:** Dismiss or suppress per source text.
- **Partial:** Weaken or suppress briefly (one exchange).
- **Miss:** No effect.

11.14 Elemental Backlash Coloring (Quick Reference)

When a magical roll generates SB (1s) or when a Partial/Miss occurs, the GM may apply a thematic backlash based on the dominant element(s).

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Element	Minor / Major Backlash Examples
Earth	Rubble, pin, heavy footing; vs Air: sound carries, exposure
Fire	Burns, flares; vs Water: slick, sputter, dim
Air	Scatter, drop, vertigo; vs Earth: stuck, dust choke
Water	Leak, flood, cold drag; vs Fire: smoke, shorted gear
Fate	Options close, “only one way”; vs Fortune: mischance hits ally
Fortune	Side-effect elsewhere, fragile success; vs Fate: harsher fixed outcome
Life	Overgrowth, fever; vs Death/Dreams: numbness, sleep-tug
Death/Dreams	Fade, threshold opens/closes; vs Life: pain returns, rot

11.15 Stacking & Duration Rules (Global)

- **No Same-Source Stacking:** Multiple scene-long effects from the same source do not stack; take the best instance.
- **Identical Tag Collision:** If two abilities would grant the same Tag in the same window, use the stronger; the weaker is suppressed while it lasts.
- **Default Duration:** Scene, unless a source states otherwise (e.g., “until the end of your next turn”).
- **DV by Fiction:** Potency, preparation, place, materials, and opposition set DV (typical 2–4; 5+ for set-pieces).

12 Rites and Invokers

This chapter covers universal rituals (available to any character with time and components) and the Invoker path (characters who channel Patrons through consecrated Symbols).

12.1 Universal Rituals

Any character, regardless of magical talent, may attempt a universal ritual. Requirements:

- A clear intent (what you want to achieve).
- A method (e.g., summoning circle, prayer, sympathetic object).
- Components (consumed or used up).
- Time (at least one scene of uninterrupted work).

12.1.1 Ritual Resolution

The GM sets a DV (typically 4–6) based on scope. The player rolls **Spirit** + **Lore** (or another appropriate skill).

- **Clean Success:** The ritual works as intended.
- **Success & Cost:** Works, but with a cost (backlash, extra time, compromised component). GM spends SB.
- **Partial:** Partial effect; player gains 1 Boon.
- **Miss:** Fails; GM may impose a complication (wrong spirit answers, ward backfires). Player gains 2 Boons.

12.1.2 Universal Rituals Table

Ritual	Tier	Cast Time	Components & Effect
Wayfinder's Thread	Low	1 min	Red cord knotted thrice; whisper destination. Create tether to safe path. Cost: Fatigue if used >1/scene. Push: +1 SB reveals shortcut.
Oath-Ward	Low	5 min	Chalk circle; sworn phrase. Ward small area vs intrusion. Cost: Breaking oath triggers SB.
Ember-Glass	Low	1 min	Smoked glass. Sense heat sources through cover. Cost: lose torch/tinder.
Salt-Cut	Low	1 min	Salt, bronze knife. Sever simple ongoing effect (rope, charm). Cost: consume salt.
River's Memory	Medium	10 min	Bowl, personal token. Scry recent event tied to token (blurry). Cost: token ruined.
Bargain-Bead	Medium	10 min	Two carved beads. Invite spirit to parley. Cost: give valuable concession or take SB.
Quiet Veil	Medium	5 min	Ash, muffled bell. Muffle group sounds for scene. Cost: Muted Condition.
Dream-Way Marker	Medium	10 min	Inked sleep mask, water cadence. Mark safe entrance to Ways Between; short transit. Cost: all Shaken on waking.
Purge	Medium	10 min	Bitter herbs, clean blade. Cleanse taint/curse one step. Cost: caster takes minor echo (−1 next action).
Summoner's Gate	High	20 min	Circle, true-name sigil. Call known entity safely. Cost: occupies concurrency slot; breaking terms creates SB.

12.2 Invokers (Symbol Path)

Invokers channel power through consecrated **Symbols** — physical tokens tied to a specific Patron.

12.2.1 Requirements

- **Patron's Symbol (4 XP each):** Minor Asset. Grants ritual access to that Patron's Rites.
- One Symbol per Patron; Invokers may carry Symbols of multiple Patrons.

12.2.2 Ritual Invocation

- Takes **DV + 1 rounds** to complete.
- Display the Symbol openly (visible).
- Always marks **+1 Obligation** to that Patron.
- If the Symbol is displayed, DV -1 and Obligation -1 (minimum 0 Obligation).

12.2.3 Crack the Seal (Instant Cast)

Resolve the Rite immediately (1 action) by:

- Marking **+2 Obligation** (+3 for High Rites).
- Setting the Symbol to **Compromised** (inert until restored).
- The GM may immediately spend 1 SB on a thematic complication.

12.2.4 Restoring a Symbol

- Requires a Downtime action.
- Roll **Wits + Arcana or Lore** (DV 3).
- **Clean Success:** Symbol returns to Maintained.
- **Partial:** Symbol becomes Neglected (future rituals +1 Obligation).
- **Miss:** Symbol remains Compromised; requires a quest or Patron service to restore.

12.2.5 Multiple Symbols

- Carrying 4 or more different Symbols causes the first Invoker ritual each scene to mark +1 additional Obligation.
- Displaying a rival Patron's Symbol while invoking another worsens Position by 1 and marks +1 Obligation to the current Patron. On any rolled 1, the GM may trigger a Patron omen or glitch.

12.3 Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Cost: 3–5 XP (minor talent). Once per scene, spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue (1 action) to gain:

- +1 die to a single combat action, **or**
- +1 Effect to a social or stealth action.

Requires visibly displaying your Patron's Symbol. If the Symbol is Compromised, Borrowed Grace works at –1 die.

12.4 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

The Traveler grants rites of safe passage, wayfinding, and road covenants. All rites below are available to Runekeepers and Invokers sworn to The Traveler.

12.4.1 Low Rites

Rite of Road-Sense (Low, Obligation: 4)

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS]

Effect: You unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far range. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* timer to ignore one instance of difficult terrain.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 SB (Clubs).

DV: max(4 - Spirit, 1).

Rite of Traveler's Boon (Low, Obligation: 5)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE]

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucratic delay. +1 Effect to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

DV: max(5 - Spirit, 1).

12.4.2 Standard Rite

Rite of the Waymark (Standard, Obligation: 8)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PASSAGE]

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* timer.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces 1 SB (Spades).

DV: max(8 - Spirit, 2).

Note: For all The Traveler's rites, the Difficulty Value is calculated as $DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Rite Tier})$ where Rite Tier is 1 for Low, 2 for Standard. Spirit reduces both the roll difficulty and the risk of Obligation overflow.

12.5 Additional Sample Rites by Patron

These Low and Standard Rites are examples. See the full Player's Guide for complete lists.

12.5.1 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn, Vows)

- **Rite of Kindle Vow (Low):** Bind a scene-long vow; bearer gains +1 die when fulfilling it.
- **Rite of Lay on Hands (Low):** Cleanse affliction, reduce Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue.
- **Rite of Radiant Smite (Standard):** Next melee attack flares with light; +1 Harm, ignores undead armor.

12.5.2 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds, Wards)

- **Rite of Sealed Threshold (Low):** Mark a doorway; unauthorized crossing requires Resolve test (DV 3).
- **Rite of Circle of Denial (Standard):** Protective circle; spirits/outsideers must resist (Resolve vs DV 4) to enter.
- **Rite of Banishment Knot (High):** Cast out a supernatural entity; test vs its Cap.

12.5.3 Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides, Storms)

- **Rite of Tidemark's Blessing (Low):** Steady footing on wet surfaces; +1 die to balance/climb.
- **Rite of Whispering Currents (Low):** Learn safest route on water; +1 die to navigation.
- **Rite of Wave-Road Blessing (Standard):** Consecrate a sea lane; +2 dice to travel or evasion.

12.5.4 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Shadow, Secrets)

- **Touch the Umbral Veil (Low):** +1 die to one Stealth roll; soften a noise.
- **Rite of Crossroads Raven (Low):** Omen-raven gives +1 die to navigation or forces enemy hesitation.
- **Become the Shadow at the Crossroads (High):** Intangible to mundane harm; pass through gaps; +2 dice Stealth.

12.6 Obligation and Invokers

Invokers track Obligation per Patron (see Section ??). Each ritual invocation marks +1 Obligation (reduced by displaying the Symbol). Crack the Seal marks +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites). Obligation Capacity = **Spirit** + **Presence**. Exceeding capacity causes Fatigue.

12.7 Ritual Interruption and Counterplay

- A ritual can be interrupted by damage, loud noise, or direct countermagic before completion.
- A character may use [COUNTER] (see Section ??) to disrupt a ritual in progress.
- If interrupted, the ritual fails; components may be lost. The GM gains 1 SB.

13 Summoning

Summoning is the art of calling beings from beyond the mortal veil — spirits, elementals, the dead, fey, demons, or stranger entities. It is always dangerous, often costly, and never without consequence.

13.1 Who Can Summon?

Any character may attempt a summoning ritual, but only those with the **Pact-Whisperer** talent can reliably bind and command spirits in combat time. NPCs and plot events use the same principles: a summoner prepares a circle, pays a cost, and risks backlash.

13.2 Summoning for Narrative (Greater Powers)

Not all summonings are tactical. Sometimes the story demands calling a greater power — a patron-level entity, a forgotten god, or a primordial force. These rituals are not resolved with a single roll; they are extended challenges that drive the plot.

13.2.1 Ritual Structure for Greater Summonings

- **Preparation Timer [6–12]:** The summoner gathers rare components, secures a threshold, and learns the entity's true name (or equivalent).
- **The Calling:** A dramatic scene where the summoner rolls **Spirit** + **Lore** vs. DV (set by the entity's power). Failure may summon something else.
- **The Bargain:** Greater powers do not serve for free. They demand a price — a memory, a firstborn, a deed, or an ongoing Obligation (tracked as a campaign front).
- **Consequences:** On success, the entity manifests (briefly) and may grant a boon, answer a question, or perform a single impossible task. On failure, the entity corrupts, attacks, or curses the summoner.

Example: Summoning the Pale Shepherd’s Herald A village elder attempts to summon a death-herald to save a dying child. Preparation timer [8]: gather grave-ash, a silver bell, and the child’s true name. Calling roll: Spirit 2 + Lore 3 = 5 dice vs DV 5 → Partial. The herald appears but demands a year of the elder’s remaining life. The elder accepts; the child lives.

13.3 PC Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Player characters who specialize in summoning take the **Pact-Whisperer** talent (2 XP). This allows them to call and bind spirits for temporary aid in scenes.

13.3.1 Summoning Talents (Summary)

Refer to Section ?? for full talent descriptions. The essential summoning talents are:

- **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP):** Base access to summoning.
- **Lesser Pactwright (2 XP):** Call spirits of Cap 1.
- **Greater Pactwright (4 XP):** Call spirits of Cap 3.
- **Spirit Link (10 XP):** Spirits act on your turn; all commands are free actions; reduce Leash ticking for natural behaviours by 1.

13.4 Core Mechanics – Call, Bind, and the Leash

Summoning a spirit follows three steps: Call, Bind, and Leash management.

13.4.1 1. Call (1 Action)

The spirit manifests at Near range. Choose a spirit template (see sample templates below).

13.4.2 2. Bind (1 Boon or 1 Fatigue)

Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue to establish control. The spirit is now bound and will follow simple commands.

13.4.3 3. Leash Capacity

The spirit has a **Leash** — a track of segments equal to **Cap** + **Spirit**. Cap is the spirit’s tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater. The Leash represents the strain of keeping the spirit in the mortal world.

13.4.4 Ticking the Leash

The Leash ticks forward (gains segments) under the following conditions:

- The spirit takes Harm (1 segment per level of Harm).

- You command the spirit to act against its nature (1 segment).
- You split focus — take another significant action while the spirit is acting (1 segment).
- The spirit crosses a [WARD] without dispelling it (DV = Cap; tick segments equal to the ward's DV).
- (Optional narrative trigger) A rival contests control, or the spirit moves too far from you.

13.4.5 When the Leash Fills

When the Leash reaches its capacity, the spirit acts once according to its nature (the GM decides the action, which is often destructive or self-serving), then departs immediately (or turns hostile at the GM's discretion). The bond is broken.

13.4.6 Boon Finesse

Once per round, you may spend **1 Boon** to clear 1 tick from the current spirit's Leash (cannot be used after the Leash has already filled). This represents appeasing the spirit, reaffirming control, or offering a small token.

13.5 Commanding Spirits

- **Quick Command:** Simple orders (“attack that enemy”, “move there”, “defend me”, “retrieve that object”) do not consume your Action. You may issue one Quick Command per round as a free action.
- **Complex Command:** If the order requires interpretation, multiple steps, or finesse (“guard this door and alert me if anyone passes”, “search the room for a hidden key”), it uses your Action for the turn.
- **Spirit Link (Major Talent):** Spirits act on your turn; all commands are free actions; reduce Leash ticking for natural behaviours by 1.

13.6 Spirit Bond Progression

For spirits you summon regularly (e.g., a favoured elemental or a recurring shade), track a **Spirit Bond Timer [4]**.

- Mark segments for successful commands, shared victories, or mutual aid (once per type per session).
- At **2 segments:** Gain +1 die to communicate with this spirit type.
- At **4 segments:** The spirit becomes **Favored**. Choose one: Leash Capacity +1, or –1 tick per command (minimum 0). Additionally, the spirit grants you +1 Boon when it departs naturally (not destroyed or forced out).

13.7 Sample Spirit Templates

13.7.1 Lesser (Cap 1)

- **Shade:** Stealthy scout; can pass through cracks; Harm 1, Leash = 1+Spirit.
- **Emberling:** Small fire elemental; deals 1 Harm (fire) on touch; can ignite objects.
- **Tangle-root:** Plant spirit; can entangle one target (Entangled condition, Athletics DV 3 to break).

13.7.2 Greater (Cap 3)

- **Flame Elemental:** Area fire attack (Harm 2 to all in Close); immune to mundane fire; Leash = 3+Spirit.
- **Shadow Hound:** Track any scent; can move silently; attacks with Harm 2 (shadow bite).
- **Stone Guardian:** High defense; can interpose and reduce Harm to an ally by 1 (once per round). Harm 1, but +2 Armor.

13.8 Specializations (for recurring spirits)

Choose one specialization when a spirit becomes **Favored**:

- **Combat Specialist:** +1 Harm on attacks; ignores first Harm 1 per scene.
- **Scout Form:** Stealthy; Cap 1 can carry 2 kg, Cap 3 can carry 10 kg; +2 dice to Stealth.
- **Utility Spirit:** Can perform simple tasks (opening unlocked doors, carrying light objects, fetching items).
- **Shield Guardian:** Once per round, interpose and convert an ally's Harm 1 into Fatigue on the spirit.

13.9 GM Guidelines for Summoning

13.9.1 NPC Summoners

Treat enemy summoners as having the same limitations: they must Call (action) and Bind (Boon or Fatigue). Their spirits have a Leash timer. The GM may choose not to track Leash for minor NPCs if the fiction does not demand it, but for major antagonists, use the same mechanics — this creates tactical choices (e.g., attack the summoner to break control, or force the spirit to cross a ward).

13.9.2 Plot-Level Summonings

When the story requires a massive summoning (a demon army, a dead god, the Hollow Bride), do not use PC mechanics. Instead:

- Create a **Ritual Timer [6–12]** that the party can disrupt.

- Each segment represents a component (blood sacrifice, alignment of stars, chanting cultists).
- The party can sabotage components, kill cultists, or break the circle to halt the summoning.
- If the timer fills, the entity arrives — now the party must bargain, fight, or flee.

13.9.3 Hazards of Greater Summoning

- **Uncontrolled Manifestation:** The entity may be hostile to everyone, including the summoner.
- **Collateral Damage:** Reality warps, wards fail, the dead rise, or the environment becomes a hazard.
- **Debt:** Even if bound, the entity extracts a price — an Obligation timer that ticks per scene, demanding sacrifice or service.

Example: The Cult of the Ninth Bell Cultists attempt to summon a fragment of the Ninth (void entity). A 6-segment timer: collect nine souls (segment 1), ring the forbidden bell (segment 2), etc. The party can interrupt at any segment. If the timer fills, the Ninth Rim appears — treat as a Tier IV hazard with a Bargain (offer a memory) or a Catastrophe (reality starts erasing the town).

14 Followers and Assets

Followers and Assets represent the lasting impact of your character’s actions on the world. They are not abstractions or passive bonuses — they are people, resources, and structures that exist in the fiction and can act independently of your character.

Together, Followers and Assets allow characters to project influence beyond a single roll or scene, shaping the world through relationships, preparation, and legacy.

14.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs who have a personal relationship with your character. They may be students, allies, retainers, agents, family members, or dependents. Followers act in the fiction and can grow, change, or be lost as the story progresses.

14.1.1 What Followers Do

- **Assist** you during scenes through Bonds and Assists.
- **Act offscreen** to advance goals, gather information, or manage responsibilities.
- **Accumulate narrative weight** and may eventually become player characters.

Followers are not disposable tools. They have motives, limitations, and vulnerabilities, and the GM may place them at risk when the fiction demands it.

14.1.2 Using Followers

Followers typically influence play in three ways:

- **Assists:** Granting +1 die or narrative positioning when they are present and able to help.
- **Bond Activation:** Spending a Boon to draw on trust, loyalty, or shared history for insight or support.
- **Offscreen Action:** Handling tasks that would otherwise demand the PC's time or attention.

14.1.3 Follower States

Instead of tracking numeric timers, note a follower's Loyalty and Fitness as one of three states each.

	State	Meaning	Mechanical Effect
Loyalty	Faithful	Committed, trustworthy	Normal assist, independent actions available.
	Strained	Doubtful, pressured	Assist at –1 die; may refuse risky orders.
	Broken	Betrayed or deserted	Follower leaves or becomes hostile.
	State	Meaning	Mechanical Effect
Fitness	Ready	Uninjured, rested	Full function.
	Hurt	Wounded, exhausted	Assist at –1 die; no independent actions.
	Down	Incapacitated	Requires rescue or medical care.

Change states when the fiction demands it (e.g., after a failed mission, a moral compromise, or taking damage). No rolls are required.

14.1.4 Limits

- Followers do not replace player actions.
- Followers do not make rolls unless the GM explicitly calls for it.
- Followers cannot solve major conflicts without consequences.

When Followers succeed or fail, those outcomes become part of the story.

14.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources, positions, or structures under your character's control. They represent leverage — things that allow you to influence the world at scale.

Examples include:

- A safehouse, laboratory, or fortress.
- A mercantile network or smuggling route.
- A political office or religious authority.

- A powerful relic, symbol, or institutional role.

14.2.1 What Assets Do

Assets:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene.
- Resolve problems that cannot be solved with a single roll.
- Shape the direction and scope of the campaign.

Assets are not passive bonuses. They matter only when invoked in the fiction.

14.2.2 Asset Status

Assets have a single Status that describes their overall health and usability.

Status	Meaning	Effect
Flourishing	Well-maintained, respected	+1 die on rolls involving the asset, +1 Yield.
Stable	Normal operation	No modifier.
Strained	Problems accumulating	−1 die on asset-related rolls, no Yield.
Collapsed	Non-functional	Requires quest or major downtime to restore.

The Status worsens when the asset is neglected, attacked, or suffers a public failure. It improves through dedicated downtime actions or successful missions that benefit the asset.

14.2.3 Activating Assets

Most Assets require the expenditure of Boons to activate.

When you spend a Boon on an Asset, you may:

- Advance or halt a Timer .
- Introduce or remove a complication.
- Secure resources, protection, or access.
- Influence events happening offscreen.

The GM determines the exact impact based on the scale of the Asset and the current situation.

Activation Examples:

- *“My spy network delays the patrol — tick the Alarm timer backward by 1.”*
- *“The safehouse has a hidden exit — we escape at Controlled Position.”*
- *“My trading post provides fresh horses — remove one Supply segment.”*
- *“My guild contact suppresses the rumor — cancel an incoming complication.”*

The GM may veto an activation that exceeds the Asset’s scope.

14.3 Upkeep

During downtime, each Asset and Follower you maintain requires one of the following:

- **Attention (Intensive):** Spend a scene interacting with them (repairing, training, socializing).
- **Resources (Efficient):** Spend 1 XP (or a relevant String) to cover costs offscreen.

If you provide neither, the Asset or Follower degrades one step:

- Assets: Flourishing → Stable → Strained → Collapsed.
- Followers: Faithful → Strained → Broken.

Two consecutive downtimes without upkeep collapses the Asset or loses the Follower entirely.

14.4 Terrestrial Patrons

Not all power comes from cosmic entities. Terrestrial Patrons are mortal factions or individuals — nobles, guildmasters, crime lords, generals, merchant princes — who offer tangible aid in exchange for obligation.

14.4.1 How Terrestrial Patrons Work

When you accept a favor from a Terrestrial Patron (access, resources, protection, an Asset), you mark +1 Obligation to that patron. Your Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence) applies normally, and exceeding it causes Fatigue exactly as with cosmic Patrons (see Section ??).

Favors are typically Diamonds — leverage, rewards, or Assets that would otherwise cost XP. Examples:

- A noble grants you a safehouse (Minor Asset) in exchange for a future service.
- A guildmaster provides legal immunity (String) for one heist.
- A crime lord lends you enforcers (Cap 2 followers) for a single mission.

14.4.2 Clearing Obligation

Unlike supernatural Patrons, terrestrial obligations are cleared by performing tasks for the patron. The GM sets the scope:

- **Minor task** (deliver a message, pay a bribe): clears 1 Obligation.
- **Significant task** (escort a caravan, break a siege): clears 2 Obligation.
- **Major task** (assassinate a rival, broker a treaty): clears 3+ Obligation.

Each task becomes a story hook. Refusing a task when Obligation is full may turn the patron into a rival or enemy.

14.4.3 Benefits of Terrestrial Patrons

- No XP cost for favors — only Obligation.
- Access to Assets, Strings, and Followers you could not otherwise afford.
- Patrons escalate with your tier: a Tier I patron offers local favors; a Tier III patron offers regional power.

14.5 Player Trusts

A Trust is a shared pool of XP that players contribute to, used to acquire and maintain party-owned Assets and Followers. Trusts represent a collective enterprise — a mercenary company, a trading guild, a spy network, a religious order.

14.5.1 Forming a Trust

Any player may contribute XP to the Trust pool. Contributions are voluntary and cannot be withdrawn. The Trust has no individual owner; spending from the pool requires majority agreement.

14.5.2 What a Trust Can Buy

Cost	Benefit
4 XP	Minor Asset (shared safehouse, workshop, contact network).
8 XP	Standard Asset (guild charter, spy ring, fortress lease).
9 XP	Follower (Cap 3, loyal to the Trust, not any single PC).

Assets and Followers acquired through a Trust belong to the party as a whole. Any member may activate them (spending their own Boons).

14.5.3 Upkeep and Delegation

Each downtime, the Trust must pay upkeep for its Assets and Followers using the standard rules (1 XP or a scene per asset/follower). Alternatively, the Trust may delegate upkeep to a Cap 5 Follower:

- The Cap 5 follower can manage up to 4 Assets (or any combination of Assets and Followers totaling 4 slots).
- The follower's own upkeep covers the delegated Assets — no separate XP cost.
- **Risk:** If the follower becomes Compromised (disloyal, captured, or killed), all delegated Assets become Neglected or are lost until the follower is restored.

14.5.4 Dissolving a Trust

If the party disbands, remaining XP in the pool is lost. Assets may be transferred to individual characters who pay the XP cost (or accept Obligation to a Terrestrial Patron to cover the difference).

14.6 Followers vs. Assets vs. Patrons vs. Trusts

	Followers	Assets	Terrestrial Patrons	Trusts
Nature	People	Resources / Structures	Mortal factions	Shared pool
Primary Role	Personal support	Strategic leverage	Favors for Obligation	Collective ownership
Activation	Assists, Bonds	Boon expenditure	Accepting favors	Majority vote
Risk	Emotional, narrative	Structural, political	Refusal turns hostile	Delegated follower compromise
Growth	Can become PCs	Expand or collapse	Escalate with tier	Assets/Followers persist

14.7 High-Tier Play

As characters advance, Followers, Assets, Patrons, and Trusts become increasingly important. Higher-tier Talents and Assets consume Boons, forcing players to choose between immediate success and long-term influence.

At Tier III and above, your personal dice pool may be maxed, but a Cap 3 Follower adds +3 to assist rolls, and a Major Asset can shift the outcome of a scene without a roll.

Victory is no longer just surviving the roll. It is choosing which parts of the world move when you do.

15 Advancement & XP

Advancement in Fate's Edge reflects meaningful growth in capability and standing. XP is awarded for table-facing accomplishments, hard choices, and the dramatic friction that defines your story. Boons can be converted sparingly to accelerate growth.

15.1 Awarding XP

Choose a session pacing dial and stick to it for a campaign arc.

- **Gritty:** 4–6 XP per session (slow burn).
- **Standard:** 6–10 XP per session (default pace).
- **Heroic:** 10–14 XP per session (fast growth).

15.1.1 Session Awards (Guidelines)

Award	XP
Table attendance	+2
Major objective reached	+2–4
Discovery or lore unlocked	+1–2
Hard choice embraced	+1–2
Complication spotlight	+1–3
Bond or flag driven play	+1–2
GM curveball award	+0–3

15.1.2 Milestones

- At the conclusion of a major story arc, award +8–12 XP to all players.
- Grant +2 XP to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

15.1.3 Boon Conversion

Once per session, during downtime, a character may convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (max 2 XP via conversion per session). All normal Boon limits apply (hold 5; trim to 2 at scene end).

15.2 Spending XP

Improvement	Cost	Downtime
Attribute increase	new rating $\times$ 3 XP	new rating (days)
Skill increase	new level $\times$ 2 XP	new level (days)
On-screen Follower	Cap $\times$ 2 XP	1–3 days (recruit and brief)
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month
Talent	as listed (2–12+ XP)	as listed

15.3 Upkeep

Upkeep is paid once per Downtime period per asset or follower.

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time):** Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \lceil \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3} \rceil)$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated Downtime action with significant personal involvement.

Failure to pay: The resource degrades.

- **Follower:** Becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).

- **Asset:** Becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

15.4 Rush Rule

When you buy or upgrade an ability during downtime, you may skip the normal training time. The GM creates a Haste timer [4]. If the timer fills (e.g., from missed rolls or complications), the new ability or asset carries flaws or narrative hitches.

15.5 Tiers of Reputation

Reputation tiers reflect how the world responds to you.

Tier	XP Range	Standing
I — Rookie	0–40	Local reputation; prestige locked.
II — Seasoned	41–90	Regional notice; prestige abilities may unlock.
III — Veteran	91–150	National influence; second follower slot suggested.
IV — Paragon	151–220	Movers and shakers; rivals emerge to challenge.
V — Mythic	221+	Legendary status; kingdoms and cults respond.

15.6 High-Tier Play and Boons

As characters advance, the role of Boons shifts.

- At early tiers, Boons primarily buy reliability — negating Fatigue, stabilizing risky actions, or nudging Position.
- At higher tiers, Boons increasingly buy authority. A single Boon may force a truth, seal a pact, redirect consequences, or resolve a phase of a conflict outright.

High-tier characters typically have fewer Boons to rely on, but each spend carries greater narrative weight. This is intentional. Power at high tier comes from preparation, Bonds, oaths, and hard choices — not from inflating Difficulty Values. The world does not become harder to roll against simply because characters are stronger; instead, success and failure both reshape the story in larger ways.

15.7 Advancement Notes

- Attribute cost scaling encourages diversification over single-stat spikes.
- Skill mastery yields tangible, fiction-first benefits.
- Prestige abilities (6+ XP) should be gated by narrative milestones or patron bargains.

16 Travel Framework

Journeys are more than distance; they are sequences of pressure, discovery, and consequence. The travel framework turns long roads into a series of dramatic legs without micromanaging miles.

16.1 Legs and Travel Timers

- Break a long journey into **legs**, each representing a significant change in terrain, danger, or political region.
- Each leg uses a **Travel Timer** (default size 4 segments).
- The timer advances through progress actions, encounters, or scene resolution.
- When the timer fills, the party arrives at the destination (or the next region). Unresolved complications carry forward.

16.2 Roles on the Road

Assign one role per character each leg. Roles may rotate each leg.

Role	Key Test	Benefit on Success
Guide	Wits + Survival	Tick the Travel Timer +1.
Scout	Wits + Stealth	Party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg.
Quartermaster	Wits + Craft	Prevent one Supply drop or recover 1 spent Supply.
Watch	Presence + Notice	Party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush.

Each role action requires a roll (Attribute + appropriate skill, DV set by the GM). Failure may tick the Travel Timer backwards or introduce a complication.

16.3 Encounters and Events

Every 1–2 segments filled, the GM introduces an encounter or hazard. At minimum, each leg should include one meaningful encounter.

Type	Examples	Typical Resolution
Discovery	Ruins, strange omens, hidden sites	Investigation or exploration roll.
Hazard	Terrain challenge, illness, extreme weather	Survival or Endurance test; may use a hazard timer.
Encounter	Bandits, emissaries, beasts, rival travelers	Combat or social resolution.
Complication	Bond tested, supplies strained, pursuit gains ground	Roleplay or skill challenge.

Encounters use the standard resolution loop (Position, DV, Outcome). On a failed travel roll, the GM may spend SB to introduce an encounter immediately.

16.4 Supply and Depletion

Track shared party supplies with a **Supply Timer** [4].

- Tick the timer when the Quartermaster fails a roll, when the GM spends SB on scarcity, or when the party is forced to march without resupply.
- When the timer fills, the party runs out of a critical resource (food, water, fuel). Apply a Condition (Hungry, Thirsty, etc.) or mark 1 Fatigue per character.
- Resupply at settlements, through successful foraging, or by spending a Cache token (see Asset rules).

16.5 Optional: Regional Travel Decks

If using the optional Regional Decks, draw a card from the destination's deck when the Travel Timer ticks. Suits suggest the nature of the encounter:

Suit	Theme
Spades	Place – a landmark, ruin, or terrain feature.
Hearts	Actor – a traveler, patrol, or local guide.
Clubs	Pressure – weather, injury, resource loss.
Diamonds	Leverage – a shortcut, a cache, or a friendly face.

The highest rank may set the Travel Timer size (e.g., 4 for 2–5, 6 for 6–10, 8 for Jack–King, 10 for Ace).

16.6 Weather and Terrain Modifiers

The GM may apply modifiers based on conditions:

Condition	Effect
Difficult Terrain	Movement costs double; Charge/Skirmish require open ground
Extreme Weather (rain, snow, heat)	First travel roll each leg is Desperate.
Hazardous Weather (storm, blizzard, sandstorm)	Travel Timer ticks +1 at leg start; navigation DV +1.
Favorable Weather	First travel roll each leg gains +1 Position.

16.7 Foraging and Subsistence

A character may forage during a leg instead of taking a role action. Roll Wits + Survival (DV by terrain, typical 3–4).

- **Clean Success:** Gain 1 Supply.

- **Partial:** Gain 1 Supply but mark 1 Fatigue (time or exposure).
- **Miss:** No Supply; GM gains 1 SB (scarce resources, dangerous plant, predator sign).

16.8 GM Quick Cues

- Travel should advance story stakes, not pause them. Use legs to foreshadow threats, deepen bonds, or reveal Patron omens.
- Let players showcase talents in their chosen roles.
- Mix discovery and hardship to keep legs tense but rewarding.
- A failed travel roll should never result in “nothing happens.” Use SB to introduce an encounter or tick a hazard timer.

17 Encounters

All encounters — combat, social, environmental, magical — use the same core engine: Position, Effect, DV, Boons, and Story Beats (SB). Timers track progress toward resolution or the escalation of threats.

17.1 Common Framework

1. **State Intent & Approach.** What do you want to achieve, and how?
2. **Set Position & DV.** GM determines risk (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) and difficulty (2–7+).
3. **Roll Attribute + Skill.** Each 6+ = success; each 1 = SB for the GM.
4. **Apply the Outcome Matrix.** Clean Success, Success & Cost, Partial, Miss.
5. **Spend SB.** GM introduces complications, shifts Position, or advances timers.

17.2 Timers in Encounters

Timers track cumulative progress or increasing pressure.

- **Progress Timer** (4–8 segments): Fill to succeed (e.g., persuasion, escaping a maze).
- **Threat Timer** (4–8 segments): Fill to trigger a disaster (e.g., reinforcements, structural collapse).
- **Contest Timers:** Two timers — one for each side; first to fill wins.

Ticking Timers:

- Partial: 1 tick (GM discretion).
- Clean Success: 2 ticks.

- **Miss:** may tick opposition timers.
- GM may spend SB to tick a timer.

17.3 Social Encounters

Use Persuasion Timers for extended negotiations, debates, or intimidation.

17.3.1 Setting Up

- **Target's Resolve:** Easy (4-segment), Moderate (6-segment), Hard (8-segment).
- **Initial Position:** Based on relationship, leverage, and setting (Dominant = mutual trust, Desperate = hostile audience).
- **DV:** Standard ladder (3–7+) with modifiers for cultural gaps, time pressure, etc.

17.3.2 Non-Face Characters Can Help

- **Setup:** Create an advantage — produce evidence, cause a distraction, or perform a display of force. Roll an appropriate skill. On success, grant the primary speaker +1 Position or +1 die.
- **Assist:** Spend 1 Boon to give +1 die (narrated as a timely interjection or meaningful glance).
- **Interrupt:** On a Miss, a non-face character can take the fallout (e.g., absorb a social rebuke) by marking 1 Fatigue.

17.3.3 Persuasion Rolls

Each distinct argument or lever advances the timer:

- **Clean Success:** +2 segments.
- **Partial:** +1 segment; GM may spend SB for a complication (e.g., “They agree, but you will owe a favor”).
- **Miss:** No progress; GM may tick an Opposition Timer (4–6 segments).

When the Opposition Timer fills, the target hardens — Position worsens or the ask becomes impossible. When the Persuasion Timer fills, the target agrees as framed.

17.4 Environmental Encounters

17.4.1 Terrain and Positioning

- **Height Advantage:** +1 die or +1 Effect for attacks from above.
- **Cover:** Partial cover (+1 DV to target you); Full cover (cannot be targeted directly). You may Hide behind full cover (Stealth vs Perception).

- **Difficult Terrain:** Costs 2 Move actions to traverse one band (or a full action to Dash). Charge/Skirmish require open ground unless the Relentless talent is used.

17.4.2 Hazards and Timers

Active hazards (fire, flooding, toxic gas) are represented by Threat Timers:

- Tick the timer on missed rolls, GM SB spends, or at scene intervals.
- When the timer fills, the hazard triggers (e.g., collapse, wave of fire).
- Characters may attempt to slow or disable the hazard (e.g., Tinker to seal a gas leak, Magic to freeze spreading flames). Treat as a Progress Timer .

Example: Collapsing Bridge [6] — ticks on each Partial or Miss. At 3 segments, footing becomes Desperate; at 6, the bridge falls.

17.5 Magical Encounters

17.5.1 Adjudicating Spells in Combat

- **Free Caster (Spellcraft):** Weave then Cast (2 actions). Push (mark Fatigue) to compress to 1 action. Casting while Engaged worsens Position by one step unless the spell has [TOUCH] or [WARD].
- **Runekeeper (Rites):** Invoke a Rite as 1 action; mark Obligation. Push It (+1 Obligation) for increased effect.
- **Invoker (Symbols):** Ritual takes DV+1 rounds. Crack the Seal (instant) marks +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites); Symbol becomes Compromised.
- **Cantor (Songs):** Sing a Song (1 action, resolves at start of next turn). Push to resolve immediately (mark Fatigue + advance Corruption).

17.5.2 Traps and Wards

- **Discover:** Notice vs DV 4–6.
- **Disable:** Contested roll vs trap’s tick. Clean Success = neutralized; Partial = disable but generate SB; Miss = trap activates.
- **Activation:** GM spends SB to trigger trap (damage, condition, timer advance).
- **Wards:** Magical barriers with a DV (3–6). Crossing without dispelling triggers the effect and ticks any relevant Leash by the ward’s DV.

17.5.3 Summoning and Spirits

- **Leash Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.

- **Ticks:** Spirit takes Harm (1 per Harm level); acts against its nature (1); crosses a ward without dispelling (ticks = ward's DV); split focus (1).
- **Leash fills:** Spirit acts once to its nature (potentially hostile) then departs.
- **Boon Finesse:** Summoner may spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick (once per round).

17.6 Extended Rituals and Downtime Encounters

Use a Progress Timer (4–12 segments). Each segment represents a scene or a block of time. Players describe their approach and roll an appropriate skill; success advances the timer. Complications (GM SB) may add segments, require rare components, or draw unwanted attention.

17.7 Quick Reference Table

Encounter Type	DV (Default)	Typical Skills	Common Timers
Combat	3 (Controlled)	Melee, Ranged, Athletics, Command	Mob Overwhelm [6], Hazard [4–8]
Social	3 (Controlled)	Sway, Subterfuge, Insight, Command	Persuasion [4–8], Opposition [4]
Environmental	3–4 (varies)	Athletics, Survival, Tinker, Stealth	Collapse [6], Flood [6], Chase [4]
Magical	4–6 (specific)	Arcana, Lore, Spirit+Resolve	Leash [Cap+Spirit], Ritual [6–12]

17.8 GM Reminders

- Let non-specialists contribute — use Setup and Assist actions, and allow creative skill use.
- Spend SB to escalate, not punish. A well-spent SB changes the situation, creating new choices.
- Timers make progress visible. When a timer ticks, describe what changes in the fiction.
- Follow the procedure for Armor & Fatigue: convert, apply remaining Harm (clears existing Fatigue), then add Fatigue. Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.

18 Complications & Timers

Complications are the narrative, mechanical, and environmental consequences that arise from failure, pressure, or the GM spending Story Beats. Timers are the primary tool for tracking accumulating threats or progress.

18.1 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are the GM's currency for introducing complications. Each die result of 1 generates 1 SB. Re-rolling a 1 does not erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

18.1.1 SB Spend Menu

SB Cost	Effect
1	Minor pressure: noise, trace, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1, worsen Position by one step.
2	Moderate setback: alarm raised, lose cover/advantage, a lesser foe appears, split the party briefly.
3	Serious trouble: reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks (temporarily), a major twist shifts the scene.
4+	Scene-shaping turn: a trap springs, authority arrives, the environment changes dramatically, a Patron

18.1.2 Limits on SB per Scene

- Base SB budget: 4 + highest character Tier (e.g., Tier I = 5, Tier III = 7).
- Maximum 12 SB for standard scenes, 16 SB for climactic scenes.
- Unspent SB may carry over between scenes (GM discretion, max 4).

18.2 Boons (Player Resource)

Boons are the players' resource for mitigating complications or turning the tide. See Section ?? for detailed earning and spending rules.

18.3 Timers

Timers track accumulating threats or progress. They are a visible way to manage pressure.

18.3.1 When to Use a Timer

- **Threat Timer** (4–8 segments): Fills with enemy action, environmental decay, or social collapse. When full, a defined disaster occurs.
- **Progress Timer** (4–8 segments): Fills with player successes to achieve a goal (e.g., escape, research, negotiation).
- **Contest Timers:** Two timers race – first to fill wins.

18.3.2 Ticking Timers

Timers advance when:

- The GM spends SB (e.g., 1 SB = tick a relevant timer +1).
- A failed roll directly relates to the threat (GM discretion).
- A scene transition or scripted event occurs.

18.3.3 Example Timers

- **Guards Incoming [6]** – ticks on noise or missed stealth. On fill, a patrol arrives.
- **Collapsing Bridge [4]** – ticks on failed Athletics or heavy impacts. On fill, bridge falls.
- **Patron's Patience [8]** – ticks each time Obligation is ignored. On fill, Patron demands service.

18.4 Hazards

Hazards are ongoing complications that require action to avoid or mitigate.

18.4.1 Environmental Hazards

- **Active:** Fire spreading, flooding, toxic gas – represented by a Threat Timer that ticks each round or on SB spends.
- **Passive:** Difficult terrain, darkness, extreme heat/cold – impose Position penalties or DV modifiers.

18.4.2 Social Hazards

- **Rumors:** A timer that advances when the party fails social rolls; when full, a faction turns hostile.
- **Scrutiny:** Worsens Position for stealth or deception.
- **Reputation Damage:** Future social rolls start at worse Position.

18.4.3 Magical Hazards

- **Backlash Zone:** An area where free casting automatically generates +1 SB per spell.
- **Ward / Seal:** Requires a roll to pass; failure triggers a consequence (harm, alarm, etc.).
- **Leaking Veil:** Spirits or fey occasionally manifest spontaneously (GM spends SB to introduce).

18.5 Fear Effects

When a character escalates on the Fear Track (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), roll or choose an effect from the table below. Apply to NPCs by default; PCs may adopt as narrative guidance.

d10	Effect	Magic Tags
1	Freeze: Cannot act this round, staring or trembling.	Silence, Stasis
2	Flee: Must move at full speed away from the source of Fear.	Movement, Wind
3	Drop: Drops what they are holding.	Disarm, Break
4	Beg: Pleads or bargains incoherently.	Compulsion, Voice
5	Hide: Seeks cover, concealment, or allies.	Shadow, Illusion
6	Attack in Panic: Lashes out wildly at the nearest target.	Rage, Fire
7	Blunder: Stumbles into danger (trap, hazard, off balance).	Chaos, Trickery
8	Obeys: Instinctively follows a simple command from the fear-causer.	Command, Charm
9	Break Down: Sobs, prays, or becomes useless until aided.	Curse, Despair
10	Catatonia: Becomes unresponsive, requiring intervention.	Sleep, Dream

18.5.1 Fear Track Escalation

- **Shaken:** Apply minor effects (hesitation, −1 die, startled).
- **Frightened:** Roll normally on the table.
- **Panicked:** Apply severe or exaggerated results (e.g., 2 = reckless flight into danger, 6 = attacks allies).

18.6 The Deck of Consequences (Optional)

The Deck of Consequences is a narrative tool that turns Story Beats into thematic, unpredictable complications. It replaces or supplements GM fiat with randomized twists.

18.6.1 Deck Structure

Use a standard 52-card deck (jokers optional). Suits map to complication themes:

Suit	Theme
Hearts	Social / Emotional
Spades	Physical / Harm
Clubs	Material / Cost
Diamonds	Magical / Spiritual

18.6.2 Rank Severity

- 2–5: Minor inconvenience (noise, Fatigue 1, small delay).
- 6–10: Moderate setback (alarm raised, gear broken, Position worsened).
- J, Q, K: Major consequence (reinforcements, key gear destroyed, front timer advanced).
- A: Severe twist (trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts).

18.6.3 When to Draw

The GM may draw from the deck when:

- A roll shows two or more 1s.
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats at once.
- A major timer fills (scene or campaign timer).
- During travel to generate an unexpected encounter.

Aim for 1–2 draws per session; more if the tone skews chaotic.

18.6.4 Procedure

1. Note the number of SB spent (or generated).
2. Draw a number of cards equal to the SB spent (minimum 1, maximum 3).
3. Synthesize a single narrative complication from the combination of suits and the highest rank.
4. Do not reshuffle until the deck runs out or the session ends – this creates a natural “fate budget.”

18.6.5 Shortcut Table for Synthesis

Suit High (J–A)	Low (2–5)
Hearts Betrayal, scandal, broken trust	Awkward social moment
Spades Serious injury, structural collapse	Bruise, small stumble
Clubs Major asset destroyed, debt called	Minor loss (rations, coins)
Diamonds Patron demand, reality bends	Omen, eerie noise

18.7 Integrating Complications with SB and Boons

- SB and Boons create a push-pull: SB gives the GM tools to escalate; Boons give players tools to recover or resist.
- A well-spent SB should change the situation, not just punish. Offer the player a Devil’s Bargain: “I will spend 2 SB to have the guard turn around – but you will owe a favor.”
- Timers make threat visible; when a timer ticks, describe what changes in the fiction.

18.8 Example: Complication in Action

Lyra misses a stealth roll (0 successes) while sneaking past a guard post. She gains 2 Boons. The GM spends 1 SB: “Your foot scrapes a loose stone – the guard looks up.” (Tick *Guards Alert* [4/+1].)

Later, the GM spends another 2 SB: “The guard calls for backup – two more arrive. New timer: *Reinforcements* [6].” Lyra uses 1 Boon to re-roll a failed athletics test to climb a wall, escaping just as the timer reaches 4.

Another scene: Lyra rolls three 1s on a critical casting. The GM draws three cards from the Deck of Consequences: Knave of Hearts, 7 of Clubs, Ace of Spades. Synthesis: “You slip past the first guard, but your cloak catches on a rusty nail (resource drain). Worse, the second guard recognizes your face from a wanted poster – she is your cousin (social betrayal). She hesitates, then shouts ‘Traitor!’ As she draws her blade, a hidden portcullis drops behind you (scene shift). You are trapped in the courtyard.”

19 Deck of Consequences (Optional)

The Deck of Consequences is a narrative tool for injecting drama, setbacks, and twists. It replaces or supplements GM fiat with randomized complications that remain thematically consistent. Its use is entirely optional.

19.1 Deck Structure

Use a standard 52-card deck (jokers optional). Suits map to complication themes:

Suit	Theme	Examples
Hearts	Social / Emotional	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust, awkward moment, ally under strain.
Spades	Physical / Harm	Bruise, injury, collapse, gear damage, ambush.
Clubs	Material / Cost	Resource loss, gear failure, debt, ruined supplies, theft.
Diamonds	Magical / Spiritual	Omen, curse, Patron attention, reality bend, haunting.

19.2 Card Ranks & Severity

- **Ace:** Scene-altering twist; compels immediate response.
- **King, Queen, Jack:** Major complication with lasting effects.
- **10–8:** Moderate complication that reshapes the current scene.
- **7–5:** Minor complication; a nuisance that creates tension.
- **4–2:** Subtle complication or foreshadowing omen.

19.3 Jokers (Optional)

- **Red Joker:** Catastrophic event (environmental collapse, Patron intervention).
- **Black Joker:** Dark boon (immediate help, but with lasting cost or debt).

19.4 When to Draw

The GM may draw from the deck when:

- A roll shows multiple 1s (e.g., three or more).
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats at once.
- A major timer fills (scene or campaign timer).
- During travel to generate an unexpected encounter.

Aim for 1–2 draws per session; more if the tone skews chaotic.

19.5 Procedure

1. Note the number of SB spent (or generated).
2. Draw a number of cards equal to the SB spent (minimum 1, maximum 3).
3. Synthesize a single narrative complication from the combination of suits and the highest rank.
4. Do not reshuffle until the deck runs out or the session ends — this creates a natural “fate budget.”

19.5.1 Synthesizing Complications

Combine the suits and the highest rank into one fiction-first twist.

Examples:

- **Hearts + Spades:** Emotional betrayal that leads to physical harm (“Your ally flees, and the portcullis drops between you.”).
- **Clubs + Diamonds:** Resource drain with magical backlash (“The ritual consumes your healing herbs and leaves a scar on the threshold.”).
- **All four suits:** A crowd riots, loots your supplies, and a spirit feeds on the chaos.

19.6 Shortcut Table for Fast Interpretation

Suit	Low (2–5)	High (J–A)
Hearts	Awkward social moment	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust
Spades	Bruise, small stumble	Serious injury, structural collapse
Clubs	Minor loss (rations, coins)	Major asset destroyed, debt called
Diamonds	Omen, eerie noise	Patron demand, reality bends

19.7 Integration with Fiction

- Translate the raw card result into a fiction-first complication. Do not apply mechanical penalties alone.
- The complication should build on what is already happening in the scene, not restart the story.
- Respect player agency — allow clever mitigation, but ensure the consequence lands.

19.8 GM Quick Cues

- Use the deck to surprise yourself as well as the players.
- If a card does not fit the current fiction, draw again or adjust the rank up or down by one.
- For campaign-scale foreshadowing, draw a card at the end of a session and note its theme; introduce the complication in a later session.

20 Crown Spread (Optional)

The Crown Spread is a campaign-framing tool that uses a spread of cards to establish the long arc of a story. It provides seeds for GMs and players to weave motifs, omens, and foreshadowed events. Its use is entirely optional.

20.1 Setup

- In Session Zero (or before the campaign begins), lay out 5–7 cards in a semicircle (the “Crown”). Use either the Deck of Consequences or a standard card deck.
- Each card anchors a motif, omen, or looming event.
- Record the spread openly on a Campaign Sheet or digital log.

20.2 Interpreting the Spread

Position	Meaning
Position 1 (Root)	The underlying tension or theme of the campaign.
Position 2 (Crest)	A key faction or patron influence that will rise.
Position 3 (Crown)	The climax image or major confrontation the arc builds toward.
Position 4 (Left Hand)	A bond, ally, or relationship that anchors play.
Position 5 (Right Hand)	A rival, betrayer, or challenger who pressures the party.
Positions 6 & 7 (Optional)	Expansions for setting-wide twists (environmental, mystical, or political).

20.3 Using the Spread in Play

- Each drawn card becomes a **Foreshadow Timer [4]** attached to its motif. Advance the timer when events lean toward that omen (e.g., when the GM spends SB on related complications, when a major scene involves that faction, or when a travel leg passes through an area tied to the motif).
- When a Foreshadow Timer fills, the motif manifests concretely in play — a faction rises, a betrayer reveals themselves, a curse activates.
- Tie Spread cards to Campaign Timers for pacing.

20.4 Campaign Timer

The Campaign Timer tracks rising stakes across the entire arc.

- Default size: **[8]** segments.
- Advance the Campaign Timer when: multiple SB overflows in a session (e.g., three or more 1s on a single roll), when travel legs resolve with major cost (e.g., a character reaches Harm 2), or when Spread omens manifest concretely.
- When the Campaign Timer fills, the Crown confrontation arrives. Play through its fallout as the campaign climax.

20.5 Ending & Legacy

- After the Crown confrontation resolves, hold an epilogue session.
- Resolve any remaining Foreshadow Timers as epilogue vignettes.
- Players may mark **Legacy Bonds** — new anchors for future campaigns or descendants.

20.6 GM Quick Cues

- The Spread is not a railroad — it foreshadows, not dictates.
- Reinterpret cards liberally as play evolves; symbols matter more than literal events.
- Remind players of their omens between arcs to build tension and payoff.

21 Player Archetypes at the Table

Fate's Edge gameplay flexes to different player archetypes. These roles are not strict classes but rather approaches to play that help a group balance spotlight and tone.

21.1 The Solo

Focus: Mastery of self, independence, one-on-one drama.

Strengths: Quick spotlight scenes, duelists, scouts, specialists.

Risks: Can drift into isolation or hog solo arcs. Needs explicit ties to group goals.

GM Tools: Use Bonds, rival duels, and one-on-one omens to keep engagement tethered to the group.

21.2 The Mixed

Focus: Hybrid adaptability — both support and lead.

Strengths: Bridges gaps in group dynamics; excels in team tactics.

Risks: May feel overshadowed by extreme specialists.

GM Tools: Spotlight them when versatility matters: flexible magic, leadership, negotiation, or sudden pivots.

21.3 The Mastermind

Focus: Schemes, plans, and command over the long arc.

Strengths: Drives strategic play, coordinates others, excels in intrigue.

Risks: May over-plan or dominate spotlight with metagame thinking.

GM Tools: Challenge them with shifting information, Patron demands, and rivals who anticipate their moves.

21.4 Balancing Archetypes

- A healthy table mixes all three archetypes, ensuring solo tension, group cohesion, and strategic play coexist.
- Encourage players to flex between archetypes scene by scene; they are fluid, not fixed.
- Spotlight balance: in a 3-hour session, each archetype should anchor at least one major scene.

21.5 GM Quick Cues

- Use archetypes as a lens for framing scenes: duels for Solos, shifting tactics for Mixed, grand reveals for Masterminds.
- When spotlight imbalances arise, rotate complications or bonds to another archetype's strength.
- Archetypes inform how Patrons and factions court PCs: Solos as champions, Mixed as envoys, Masterminds as plotters.

22 GM Guidelines

This chapter consolidates advice for running Fate’s Edge smoothly, fairly, and with narrative focus. It covers session preparation, in-play adjudication, common pitfalls, and tools for managing cognitive load.

22.1 Session Zero

Before the campaign begins, establish the following with your players.

22.1.1 Safety Tools

- **Lines:** Content that will not appear (e.g., no sexual violence, no harm to children).
- **Veils:** Content that happens off screen or fades to black.
- **X-Card:** Any player may stop a scene at any time without explanation.

Record Lines and Veils where everyone can see them. Keep an X-Card visible on the table.

22.1.2 Tone and Expectations

- What is the campaign’s primary genre? (intrigue, exploration, mercenary, horror, etc.)
- How lethal and how grim should the tone be?
- How much player vs. GM authority over the story?
- Expected session length and attendance.

22.1.3 Campaign Frame (Optional)

Consider using the Crown Spread (Section ??) to generate a shared campaign frame. Draw 5–7 cards to establish motifs, factions, omens, and a looming climax.

22.2 The 30-Second Adjudication Loop

When a player declares an action, resolve it with this loop:

1. **Clarify intent and approach.** “What do you want, and how?”
2. **Set stakes and Position.** “If it works, what changes? If it fails, what bites?” Start Dominant/Standard unless fiction says otherwise.
3. **Roll and read.** Count successes (6–9 = 1, 10 = 2); count 1s as SB.
4. **Spend one beat well.** Cash SB on one memorable twist or tick a relevant Timer .
5. **Push forward.** Describe how the fiction is now different. Ask, “Who moves next?”

22.3 Defaults That Keep Things Moving

When in doubt, use these defaults:

- **Range:** Near (unless otherwise stated).
- **Position:** Controlled.
- **Effect:** Standard.
- **DV:** 3 (2 for trivial, 4 for hard, 5+ for extreme).
- **SB budget per scene:** 4 + highest character Tier. Unspent SB may carry over (max 4).

22.4 When to Roll (and When Not To)

- **Roll when:** uncertainty exists **and** meaningful stakes are present **now**.
- **Do not roll when:**
 - The outcome is certain (say “Yes”).
 - The action has no real cost or consequence.
 - The player is fishing for Boons with repetitive, low-stakes rolls.
- **Offer a choice or cost instead of a roll when:** the action is plausible but the player wants to avoid risk. “You can do it, but it will take time (tick a timer)” or “You can do it, but you will mark 1 Fatigue.”

22.5 Timers: The Three-Timer Rule

At any given time, maintain at most **three active timers** in a scene:

1. **Situation Timer :** immediate goal (persuasion, escape, research).
2. **Counter-Clock:** opposition pressure (guards arriving, ritual completing).
3. **Campaign Timer :** long-term front (faction rise, curse spreading).

Merge or retire additional timers. Timers are visible; name them and tick them in front of players.

22.6 Spending Story Beats (SB)

- **One strong beat is better than three tiny penalties.** Change the fiction, don’t just add numbers.
- **Tie SB spends to visible outcomes:** a new foe appears, a path closes, a timer advances.
- **Surprise yourself.** If you don’t know how a complication will resolve, spend SB and find out together.

22.7 Balancing Encounters by Tier

Fate's Edge does not use Challenge Ratings. Instead, consider the party's Tier and the enemy's Cap.

Party Tier	Typical Threat Cap	Notes
Tier I (0–40 XP)	Cap 1–2	Single enemies; avoid area effects.
Tier II (41–90 XP)	Cap 2–3	Lieutenants with minions.
Tier III (91–150 XP)	Cap 3–4	Bosses with phase timers.
Tier IV (151–220 XP)	Cap 4–5	Mythic threats; require preparation and assets.

22.7.1 Building an Enemy

- **Cap:** Determines dice pools, Harm output, and resistance.
- **Harm:** Typical Harm output = Cap (e.g., Cap 2 deals Harm 2 on a hit).
- **Defense DV:** 3 for standard foes, 4 for elites, 5+ for bosses.
- **Timers:** Bosses should have phase timers (6–10 segments) that change their behavior when filled.

22.8 The Four Questions (When Stuck)

Ask out loud:

1. If this goes right, what changes? (Intent)
2. If this goes wrong, what bites back? (Stakes)
3. What single twist will make this memorable? (SB spend)
4. Who moves next? (Momentum)

22.9 Common Pitfalls and Fixes

Pitfall	Fix
Over-cranking SB (scenes feel punitive)	Halve your SB spends for a while; cash into visible timers instead of immediate penalties.
Timer sprawl	Merge redundant timers. Each active scene rarely needs more than 2–3.
Tag paralysis (player waits for perfect tag)	Paraphrase: “Sounds like [VEIL]. DV 3. Want to roll?”
Rules drift	If table memory conflicts with text, pick the ruling that keeps flow, then note to reconcile after play.
Player analysis paralysis	Offer two clear options and one risky third. “You can A, B, or try something bold.”

22.10 Handling Player Creativity

- **Say “Yes, but” not “No.”** Offer a cost, a timer, or a complication.
- **Use Setup and Assist actions.** Let non-specialists contribute meaningfully.
- **Embrace unexpected solutions.** If a player bypasses a planned encounter, let it work — then escalate somewhere else.
- **Fail forward.** A missed roll should never stop the story; it should change direction.

22.11 Session Checklist

22.11.1 Before Play

- Review previous session’s fallout and unresolved timers.
- Update faction and front timers.
- Prepare 2–3 flexible scenes (not scripts).
- Set the initial Position and DV for the opening scene.
- Remind players of safety tools.

22.11.2 During Play

- Use the 30-second loop.
- Spend one strong beat per roll (not many small penalties).
- Keep timers visible and tick them openly.
- Rotate spotlight among players.
- When you don’t know a rule, make a ruling and note it for later.

22.11.3 After Play

- Award XP (Section ??).
- Advance or clear active timers.
- Note rulings to reconcile with rules text.
- Ask players: one thing they loved, one thing they want more of.

22.12 Rookie GM Comfort Dials

If you are new to Fate’s Edge, start with these training wheels:

- **Soft SB:** For your first 2 sessions, cap each roll’s SB spend to 1–2 unless it is a set-piece.
- **Visible Timers:** Put all timers on the table. Name them aloud. Tick them in ink.

- **Tag Cards:** Print one-liners for frequently used tags ([WARD], [BANISH], [COUNTER]). Hand them out when a power is active.
- **One Move, One Sentence:** Every ruling should end with one sentence that states the new situation.

22.13 Design Guardrails (for Consistency)

These principles guide rulings and homebrew:

- **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
- **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph and complication.
- **Meaningful Growth:** XP changes characters and the world.
- **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
- **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become SB.

22.14 Final Advice

The rules are rails you lay just ahead of the train. Do not let perfect knowledge of the system slow the table. When in doubt, follow the fiction, set a Position and DV, and roll. The game is designed to carry you.

23 NPC Templates

This section provides ready-to-use templates for non-player characters, from common guards to supernatural spirits. Each template includes a suggested **Cap** (capability tier), **Harm** output, typical dice pools, and special abilities. GMs may adjust values up or down by one step to suit the fiction.

23.1 Template Format

- **Name:** Type of NPC.
- **Cap:** 1–5 (training and threat level).
- **Harm:** Typical damage output on a successful hit.
- **Dice Pools:** Suggested Attribute + Skill combinations.
- **Armor:** Light / Medium / Heavy / None.
- **Special:** Unique abilities or tags.
- **Leash (for spirits):** Cap + Spirit segments.

23.2 Humanoid NPCs

23.2.1 Bandit (Tier I)

Cap: 1

Harm: 1 (club)

Dice: Melee 2d (Body 2 + Melee 0), Ranged 2d (Wits 2 + Ranged 0)

Armor: None (leather scraps, no conversion)

Special: *Cowardly* — when outnumbered or after taking Harm, must test Spirit (DV 3) or flee.

23.2.2 Guard (Tier I–II)

Cap: 2

Harm: 2 (spear or short sword)

Dice: Melee 4d (Body 3 + Melee 1), Athletics 4d (Body 3 + Athletics 1)

Armor: Light (leather) — Harm 1 → Fatigue 1.

Special: *Patrol Training* — +1 die to Notice when searching an area.

23.2.3 Knight (Tier II–III)

Cap: 3

Dice: Melee 6d (Body 3 + Melee 3), Command 5d (Presence 3 + Command 2)

Armor: Heavy (plate) — Harm 3 → Fatigue 2.

Special: *Challenge* — once per scene, force an enemy to engage in melee (Resist with Spirit, DV 4). *Mounted* —

23.2.4 Cultist (Tier I–II)

Cap: 1–2

Dice: Arcana 4d (Wits 3 + Arcana 1), Deception 4d (Presence 3 + Deception 1)

Armor: None (robes).

Special: *Ritual Chant* — when three or more cultists act together, they may perform a Low Rite as a group action.

23.2.5 Bandit Leader (Tier II)

Cap: 3

Dice: Melee 6d (Body 3 + Melee 3), Command 5d (Presence 3 + Command 2)

Armor: Medium (chain) — Harm 2 → Fatigue 1.

Special: *Rally* — once per scene, restore 1 Morale to a nearby bandit. *Dirty Fighting* — may spend 1 Boon to in

23.3 Supernatural NPCs

23.3.1 Lesser Spirit (e.g., Shade, Emberling)

Cap: 1

Dice: Stealth 5d (Wits 3 + Stealth 2), Arcana 4d (Spirit 3 + Arcana 1)

Armor: None (incorporeal — half physical Harm, rounded down)

Leash: Cap + Spirit (1 + caster's Spirit).

Special: *Incorporeal Movement* — passes through small gaps and obstacles. *Sunlight Sensitivity* — while in direct

23.3.2 Greater Spirit (e.g., Flame Elemental, Stone Guardian)

Cap: 3

Dice: 7d in primary domain (e.g., Body + Melee for Guardian, Spirit + Arcana for Elemental)

Armor: Stone Guardian — Heavy (Harm 3 → Fatigue 2); Flame Elemental — Light (Harm 1 → Fatigue 1) + in

Leash: Cap + Spirit (3 + caster's Spirit).

Special: *Elemental Aura* — creatures in Close range suffer 1 Fatigue per round. *Immutable* — cannot be poisoned

23.3.3 Wraith (Tier II–III)

Cap: 2–3

Dice: Stealth 6d (Wits 3 + Stealth 3), Spirit + Resolve 6d (Spirit 3 + Resolve 3)

Armor: None (incorporeal — half physical Harm).

Special: *Life Drain* — on a successful touch attack, the target marks 1 Fatigue and the wraith clears 1 Fatigue.

23.4 Animal NPCs

23.4.1 Wolf (Tier I–II)

Cap: 1–2 (pack)

Dice: Melee 5d (Body 3 + Brawl 2), Athletics 5d (Body 3 + Athletics 2)

Armor: None (hide).

Special: *Pack Tactics* — when two or more wolves attack the same target, each gains +1 die. *Blood Scent* — +2

23.4.2 Dire Bear (Tier III)

Cap: 4

Dice: Melee 8d (Body 4 + Brawl 4), Endurance 8d (Body 4 + Endurance 4)

Armor: Medium (thick hide) — Harm 2 → Fatigue 1.

Special: *Terrifying Roar* — all creatures in Near range must test Resolve (DV 4) or become Shaken. *Maul* — on

23.5 Building Custom NPCs

Use these guidelines to create your own NPCs quickly.

23.5.1 Step 1: Choose Cap

Cap determines overall threat level and dice pool size.

- Cap 1–2: Minions, guards, minor spirits. Dice pools 3–5.
- Cap 3–4: Elites, knights, greater spirits. Dice pools 6–8.
- Cap 5: Bosses, legendary creatures. Dice pools 9–10.

23.5.2 Step 2: Set Harm Output

- Light weapon or minor attack: Harm 1–2.
- Standard weapon or magical strike: Harm 2–3.
- Heavy weapon or powerful magic: Harm 3–4.

23.5.3 Step 3: Assign Armor

- None: No conversion.
- Light: Harm 1 $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 1.
- Medium: Harm 2 $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 1.
- Heavy: Harm 3 $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 2.

23.5.4 Step 4: Add 1–2 Special Abilities

Examples: *Charge*, *Poison*, *Fear Aura*, *Regeneration*, *Spellcasting (Low Rite)*.

23.5.5 Step 5: Set Leash (for spirits)

Leash = Cap + Spirit (use Spirit 2–4 for typical spirits).

23.6 NPC Quick Reference Table

NPC	Cap	Harm	Armor	Special
Bandit	1	1	None	Cowardly
Guard	2	2	Light	Patrol Training
Knight	3	3	Heavy	Challenge, Mounted
Cultist	1–2	1	None	Ritual Chant, Fanatic
Lesser Spirit	1	1	None (incorporeal)	Sunlight Sensitivity
Greater Spirit	3	3	Heavy (or Light + immunity)	Elemental Aura
Wraith	2–3	2 + Fatigue	None (incorporeal)	Life Drain
Wolf	1–2	2	None	Pack Tactics
Dire Bear	4	4	Medium	Terrifying Roar, Maul

A Quick Reference

A.1 Core Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	Outcome	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success	Intent achieved; no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success & Cost	Intent achieved; GM spends SB for complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial	Progress made; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss	No progress; player gains 2 Boons; GM escalates with SB.

A.2 Difficulty Value (DV) Ladder

DV	Situation
2	Routine, low stakes, nearly guaranteed.
3	Default — pressured or minor opposition.
4	Hard — hostile conditions, active resistance.
5	Extreme — multiple constraints, dramatic gambles.
6+	Nearly impossible — requires exceptional setup.

A.3 Position & Effect

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one failure.
Controlled	Balanced, normal risk	No re-rolls.
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one success.

A die showing 10 is never re-rolled.

A.4 Range Bands

Band	Default Notes
Close	Touching; grapples, knives. Polearms from Near at Limited Effect.
Near	Assumed same room/street segment; quick step away.
Far	Distant same site; needs time/route/long implement.
Absent	Off-screen; needs cut or travel to interact.

A.5 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

A.6 Fatigue and Harm

Fatigue	Effect
1 (Winded)	Dominant → Controlled.
2 (Strained)	Controlled rolls generate +1 SB on 1s.
3 (Exhausted)	Controlled → Desperate.
4+ (Collapse)	Body test DV 3 or Severe Harm.

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	−1 die on actions directly related to the injury.
Harm 2	−1 die on most actions until treated.
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying.

A.7 Magic Paths Comparison

Path	Cost	Risk	Speed	Flavor
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Backlash	2 actions (1 for cantrip)	V
Runekeeper (Rites)	Familiar + Codex	Obligation	1 action	M
Invoker (Symbols)	Patron's Symbol (4 XP)	Ritual time / Symbol damage	Slow or instant (Crack)	M
Cantor (Songs)	Cantor's Path (8 XP)	Corruption	1 action (resolve next turn)	

A.8 Summoning Leash

- **Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Ticks:**
 - Spirit takes Harm: 1 tick per Harm level.
 - Command against nature: 1 tick.
 - Split focus: 1 tick.
 - Crosses a ward without dispelling: ticks = ward's DV.
- **Leash fills:** Spirit acts once to its nature, then departs.
- **Boon Finesse:** Spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick (once per round).

A.9 Action Economy (Quick)

- Each turn: **1 Action** + **1 Move**.
- **Move:** shift one range band (Close $\leftrightarrow$ Near $\leftrightarrow$ Far).
- **Dash (Action):** move two bands; next defense Desperate.
- **Disengage (Action):** then Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; cannot Attack this turn.
- **Charge/Skirmish (Full Turn):** move two bands and attack; costs 1 Fatigue; next defense Desperate; requires open ground.

A.10 Opportunity Attacks

Moving out of an enemy's Close range without Disengage provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position). The following actions also provoke if performed while engaged in Close with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack.
- Casting a spell without [TOUCH] or [WARD].

A.11 Story Beat (SB) Spend Menu

SB Cost	Effect
1	Minor pressure: noise, trace, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1.
2	Moderate setback: alarm raised, lose Position, lesser foe appears.
3	Serious trouble: reinforcements, key gear breaks, advance a campaign timer.
4+	Major turn: trap springs, authority arrives, environment shifts dramatically.

A.12 Boons at a Glance

- **Earn:** Partial = 1 Boon; Miss = 2 Boons.
- **Hold:** max 5; trim to 2 at scene end.
- **Spend 1 Boon:** re-roll a die, activate an Asset, improve Position by one step.
- **Spend 2 Boons:** convert to 1 XP (downtime, max 2 XP per session).

A.13 Default Values (GM Cues)

- Default DV = 3.
- Default Position = Controlled.
- Default Effect = Standard.
- Default Range = Near.

A.14 Tags Quick Reference (Abridged)

c	
Tag	Effect
[AREA]	Affects all in a zone; collateral risk.
[BANISH]	Drive an Outsider toward departure; DV = target Cap.
[BARRIER]	Creates cover/obstruction with Integrity Timer .
[BIND]	Immobilizes target until broken.
[CLEANSE]	Remove or suppress a Condition.
[COMMAND]	Issue a clear order; resolve as social contest.
[CONJURE]	Create a useful object, cover, or hazard.
[COUNTER]	Interrupt a spell or rite in progress.
[CURSE]	Inflict a sticky hindrance with a clear release condition.
[DISPEL]	End or suppress an ongoing magical effect.
[FORTIFY]	Harden a target against a specific vector.
[MARK]	Tag a target; once/scene +1 die against it.
[OATH]	Bind parties to terms; breaking has teeth.
[PASSAGE]	Declare a route as permitted or easy.
[REVEAL]	Expose illusions, disguises, or hidden clauses.
[SANCTIFY]	Consecrate a zone to a code or Patron.
[SEAL] / [UNSEAL]	Magically lock or unlock a container / door.
[TRANSPORT]	Move a target across an obstacle.
[VEIL]	Obscure a person, object, or zone (−1 die to Notice).
[WARD]	Blocks specific entities (DV = target Cap to cross).

B Example Spells & Rites

This appendix provides ready-to-use examples for each magical path. DVs and costs are guidelines; GMs may adjust based on fiction.

cc		
Name	Tags & DV	Effect
Spark (Cantrip)	[FIRE] [STRIKE] DV 3	Ranged Harm 1 (fire) to one target within Near
Minor Illusion	[WATER] [VEIL] DV 3	Create a simple sound or image within Near for one c
Gust	[AIR] [PASSAGE] DV 3	Push one object or creature of your size or smaller one
Quick Patch	[LIFE] [MEND] DV 3	Temporarily repair one damaged item for the sc
Ember Cloak	[FIRE] [DEFEND] DV 3	+1 to defense DV against cold or melee attacks for t
Web of Fate	[FATE] [BIND] DV 3	Immobilize one target within Near; break free requires DV
Healing Mist	[WATER] [HEAL] [AREA] DV 4	All allies in Close regain 1 Fatigue.
Stone Shield	[EARTH] [BARRIER] DV 3	Create a stone wall with Integrity Timer [4] that blocks
Shadow Step	[AIR] [FOLD] DV 4 (dangerous)	Teleport self within Near range. Leaves faint after
Fate's Rebuke	[FATE] [STRIKE] [STRIKE] DV 4	Ranged Harm 2 (psychic), ignores non-magical ar
Sleep	[DEATH] [COMMAND] DV 3	One target within Near falls into a natural sleep; lasts scene

B.1 Runekeeper Rites (by Patron)

Runekeepers learn Rites from their Codex. Each Rite is invoked as 1 action and marks Obligation (+1 standard, +2 for Push).

B.1.1 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds, Wards, Binding)

cc

Rite	Tier	Effect
Sealed Threshold	Low	Ward a doorway; unauthorized crossing requires Spirit + Res
Circle of Denial	Standard	Protective circle vs Outsiders. To cross, Outsider tests DV = Cap
Banishment Knot	High	Cast out a supernatural entity. Test Spirit + Ritual vs target's Cap. On hit, entit

B.1.2 Raéyn (Sea, Storms, Journeys)

cc

Rite	Tier	Effect
Tidemark's Blessing	Low	Steady footing on wet surfaces; +1 die to balance and climb. Lasts scene
Whispering Currents	Low	Learn safest route on water; +1 die to navigation rolls for one leg.
Wave-Road Blessing	Standard	Consecrate a sea lane; +2 dice to travel or evasion rolls on that route for one j

B.1.3 Ikasha (Shadow, Secrets, Thresholds)

cc

Rite	Tier	Effect
Touch the Umbral Veil	Low	+1 die to one Stealth roll; soften a single
Crossroads Raven	Low	Omen-raven appears. Gain +1 die to navigation or force one ener
Become the Shadow at the Crossroads	High	Intangible to mundane harm; pass through gaps; +2 dice to

B.2 Invoker Rituals (by Symbol)

Invokers perform rituals using a Patron's Symbol. Rituals take DV+1 rounds and always mark +1 Obligation. Crack the Seal (instant) marks +2 Obligation (+3 for High) and renders the Symbol Compromised.

cc

Ritual	Patron	Effect
Oath-Ward (Low)	Any with Law/Ward domain	Chalk circle wards a small area (10ft radius). V
Wayfinder's Thread (Low)	The Traveler	Knot a red cord thrice; create a tet
Salt-Cut (Low)	The Sealed Gate	Sever a simple ongoing magical effect (rop
River's Memory (Standard)	Raéyn	Scry a recent event tied to a personal token
Bargain-Bead (Standard)	Any Patron	Invite a minor spirit to parley. Requires
Purge (Standard)	Oath of Flame & Light	Cleanse one level of taint, curse, or corruption from
Summoner's Gate (High)	Any with Summoning domain	Call a known entity safely. Requires circle and

B.3 Cantor Songs

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs. Singing takes 1 action; the effect resolves at the start of the caster's next turn. Push (mark Fatigue + advance Corruption) resolves immediately.

cc

Song	Patron / Theme	Effect
Hearth's Lullaby	Mercy, Rest	All allies within Near recover 1 Fatigue.
Storm's Call	Weather, Sea	For one leg, treat weather hazards as one step milder (does not stack).
Raven's Omen	Shadow, Secrets	One ally gains +1 die to their next Stealth or Subterfuge roll.
Knot of Silence	Binding, Ward	Muffle all sound within Close range for one exchange.
Thread of Memory	Knowledge, Truth	Ask the GM one yes/no question about a past event in the current scene.
Bitter Dirge	Death, Endings	One enemy within Near suffers -1 die to their next action (fear).

B.4 Universal Rituals (Any Character)

Any character with the time, components, and a skill roll (usually Spirit + Lore) may attempt these rituals.

cc

Ritual	Time & Components	Effect
Wayfinder's Thread	1 min, red cord	Tie thrice; create tether to a safe path. On success, the tether can be used to pull or push objects.
Oath-Ward	5 min, chalk circle	Ward small area; violators take 1 die of damage.
Ember-Glass	1 min, smoked glass	Sense heat sources through the glass.
Salt-Cut	1 min, salt, bronze knife	Sever a simple ongoing effect (rope, candle, etc.).
River's Memory	10 min, bowl, personal token	Scry a recent event tied to token; success reveals details.
Bargain-Bead	10 min, two carved beads	Invite a minor spirit to parley. On success, the spirit grants a boon.
Quiet Veil	5 min, ash, muffled bell	Muffle group sounds for one scene.
Dream-Way Marker	10 min, inked sleep mask, water cadence	Mark safe entrance to the Ways Between; success reveals details.
Purge (Tainted Object)	10 min, bitter herbs, clean blade	Cleanse one level of taint from a small object.

C Example Characters

These Tier I (32 XP) characters illustrate core builds for different playstyles. Each includes attributes, skills, talents, equipment, a bond, and a complication.

C.1 Ellis — Aeler Initiate (Warrior/Runekeeper)

A young vent-prior's apprentice who left the underways to prove that stone-law can walk the surface world without breaking.

Attributes

Body 3 Wits 2
Spirit 3 Presence 2

Skills

Melee 2, Athletics 1, Endurance 1, Lore 1, Craft 1, Survival 1

Talents (12 XP total)

- **Familiar (Thiasos) (2 XP)** — A small iron bell that hums when stone is near.
- **Codex (4 XP)** — Sealed with a keystone rune; contains the Rites of the Sealed Gate.
- **Weapon Master (5 XP)** — +2 dice with warhammer; once/scene +1 Effect.
- **Effortless Charge (4 XP)** — Ignore Fatigue cost of Charge once/scene.

Equipment

- Warhammer (Medium melee, Harm 2, +1d at Close, +2d at Near).
- Iron Half-Plate (Medium armor, 1 Harm → 1 Fatigue, 2 Harm → 1 Fatigue).
- Codex (iron-bound slate).
- Breath-counter bell.

Bond

“I owe Vent-Prior Orla a debt of stone and silence. She taught me that the mountain listens even when we do not speak.”

Complication

Stone-Press Susceptible: In deep underground spaces, any failed roll ticks a personal Hallucination Timer [4].

Rites Known

- **Sealed Threshold** (Low) — Ward a doorway; unauthorized crossing requires Resolve test.
- **Oath-Ward** (Low) — Chalk circle wards a small area vs intrusion.

C.2 Lyra — Vilikari Rover (Rogue/Scout)

A border-runner who learned to read two ledgers before she could write her name, now carries secrets instead of cargo.

Attributes

Body 2 Wits 4
Spirit 2 Presence 3

Skills

Stealth 2, Subterfuge 2, Sway 2, Investigation 1, Tinker 1, Insight 1

Talents (12 XP total)

- **Keen Senses (2 XP)** — +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.
- **Trackless Step (2 XP)** — Once/scene, leave no trail for the remainder of the scene.
- **Silk Palms (2 XP)** — When you bribe a minor official, gain temporary String *Bought Silence*.
- **Backstab (6 XP)** — When attacking from stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of Armor.

Equipment

- Paired daggers (Light melee, Harm 1, +2d at Close, +1d at Near).
- Padded leather (Light armor, 1 Harm → 1 Fatigue, 2 Harm → 1 Harm + 1 Fatigue).
- Lockpicks (Tinker kit).
- False manifest (forged papers).

Bond

“Rurik the fence saved me from a customs trap. He expects me to return the favor when the ledger calls.”

Complication

Two-Ledger Debt: You keep a second ledger of favors owed to Vilikari smugglers. The GM may once per session tick a *Favor Due* timer [4] when you refuse a questionable job.

C.3 Sera — Lethai-thora Exile (Caster)

A former archivist who touched a forbidden scroll and now hears whispers from the space between written words.

Attributes

Body 2 Wits 4
Spirit 3 Presence 2

Skills

Arcana 2, Lore 3, Insight 2, Investigation 1, Deception 1

Talents (10 XP total)

- **Spellcraft (6 XP)** — Enables freeform casting (Weave + Cast).
- **Long Memory (3 XP)** — +1 die to Lore and Insight rolls involving historical knowledge.
- **Cold Reading (3 XP)** — +1 die to Sway and Insight when observing before acting.

Equipment

- Quarterstaff (Light melee, Harm 1, +2d at Close, can Defend as action).
- Scholar's robes (no armor).
- Sealed scroll case (contains one forbidden fragment).
- Brass inkpot (focus for [REVEAL] effects).

Bond

“Keeper Lian hid me when the Censorate came. Her silence protects me; my voice will one day protect her secret.”

Complication

Whisper-Threshold: Whenever you cast a spell that generates two or more SB, you hear a voice from the Ninth Scroll. The GM gains a String: *The Archive Knows Your Name*.

Signature Spells

- **Whisper-Light** ([FIRE][ILLUMINATE]) — DV 3, one action. Small, silent light.
- **Memory's Veil** ([WATER][VEIL]) — DV 3, two actions. Obscure one small object or door; -1 die to Notice.
- **Scroll's Rebuke** ([FATE][STRIKE]) — DV 3, two actions. Ranged Harm 1 (psychic), ignores mundane armor.